

## GRILLBY, SWEDEN, 1994



## THE LIGHT THAT STOPPED A CAR

# INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER

## Editor:

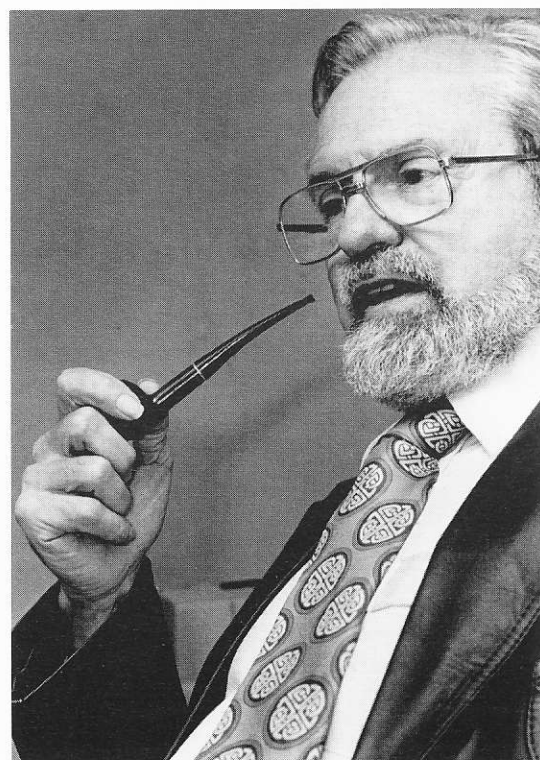
Jerome Clark

## Associate Editor:

George M. Eberhart

## Contributing Editors:

Bill Chalker  
Richard F. Haines  
Richard Hall  
Kevin D. Randle  
Jenny Randles  
Mark Rodeghier  
Chris Rutkowski  
Jennie Zeidman



*J. Allen Hynek*  
1910-1986

|                                                    |                                  |    |
|----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----|
| THE GLUE EXPLANATION JUST WON'T STICK              | by Robert A. Galganski           | 3  |
| UFO CRASH AT SHAG HARBOUR                          | by Don Ledger                    | 8  |
| LOUISIANA LIGHTS IN 1967                           | by John O. Williams              | 10 |
| SCIENTIFIC PANEL: UFO EVIDENCE BEARS INVESTIGATION |                                  | 11 |
| THE LIGHT THAT STOPPED A CAR                       | by Clas Svahn and Jörgen Granlie | 12 |
| OUT OF THE SKY? A CURIOUS STORY OF 1911            | by Elsie Shirley                 | 13 |
| TULLY SAUCER NESTS OF 1966—PART ONE                | by Bill Chalker                  | 14 |
| MY MISSION FROM THE ASHTAR COMMAND                 | by Bruce Maccabee                | 21 |
| LETTERS TO THE EDITOR                              |                                  | 28 |

*International UFO Reporter* (ISSN 0720-174X) is published quarterly by the J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659. All rights reserved. Reproduction without permission is strictly prohibited. Copyright © 1998 by the J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies. Third-class postage paid at Chicago, Illinois.

Advertisements accepted for publication in this magazine do not necessarily reflect the viewpoints of the J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies.

Address all article submissions, letters to the editor, and other editorial correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, Center for UFO Studies, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago,

Illinois 60659. Address all subscription correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659.

The *International UFO Reporter* is a benefit publication mailed to Associates of the Center for a contribution of \$25.00 or more. Foreign Associates add \$5.00 for delivery. All amounts in U.S. funds. Other publications also available for contributors of larger amounts. For details, write to the J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659, USA. **Postmaster:** Send Form 3579 to CUFOS, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659.

---

# THE GLUE EXPLANATION JUST WON'T STICK

BY ROBERT A. GALGANSKI

---

## Why the struts found with the Roswell debris were *not* balsa wood.

---

**R**ectangular and I-shaped cross-section thin-strut fragments recovered from the Foster ranch debris field in early July 1947 allegedly displayed extraordinary physical properties. Persons who handled them said they were extremely lightweight, slightly flexible but unbreakable, and could not be cut or burned. Roswell skeptics dismiss these reports, attributing them to the vagaries of long-term memory and embellished accounts of similar wreckage—specifically, balsa wood sticks—from rawin radar targets comprising Project Mogul Flight 4.

Former Mogul project engineer Charles B. Moore hinted that specially treated balsa wood used in those targets may have contributed to the wood misidentification problem. In an October 31, 1994, *People* magazine article titled “A Saucer Scorned,” he indicated that “the balsa wood was soaked in glue, like Elmer’s Glue. It’s a casein product [a protein derived from milk] that just won’t burn at all.” Moore added that the glue made the wood “a little bit stiffer and less easy to dent than ordinary balsa.”

Moore also referred to altered balsa-wood characteristics in the 1995 Crystal Sky Production video, *Roswell Remembered*, stating that “. . . some of them [the sticks] appeared to have been stiffened by having something like Elmer’s Glue on them.” Curiously, he did *not* discuss the subject in his most recent and complete recollection of Project Mogul (Benson Saler, Charles A. Ziegler, and Charles B. Moore, *UFO Crash at Roswell: The Genesis of a Modern Myth*, Herndon, Va.: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1997).

The glue-treated balsa-wood sticks were also discussed by Kent Jeffrey as part of his recent 180-degree reversal on

the Roswell Incident (Kent Jeffrey, “Roswell—Anatomy of a Myth,” *MUFON UFO Journal*, June 1997, pp.3–17). He speculated that the glue “would probably have given them a different color than that of raw wood, as well as a different feel or texture—probably to the degree that someone who didn’t know them for what they were, might not recognize them as wood.”

In summary, Moore and Jeffrey suggest that balsa wood sticks coated with an Elmer’s Glue-like substance were unrecognizable from and stiffer than raw balsa wood, and noncombustible. The stiffness has been cited by Roswell skeptics to explain why the thin-strut fragments found on the Foster ranch could not be broken by human hands.

I conducted three series of simple experiments to test the “glue hypothesis.” This article presents my findings.

### TEST SPECIMEN SELECTION

Because it’s been more than 50 years since the original Project Mogul Flight 4 rawin radar targets were fabricated, my experiments utilized currently available materials. Published descriptions and additional information graciously provided by Charles Moore formed the basis for their selection.

**Balsa wood.** Ordinary 5/16-inch (8 mm) square balsa-wood sticks available from any hobby shop were used. Because wood is a natural product, the physical properties of these sticks were probably similar to the original struts used in rawin target construction. The first series of experiments was conducted with unmodified (raw) balsa wood.

**Glue.** Consistent with Moore’s recollection, the second series of experiments utilized balsa-wood sticks coated with Elmer’s Glue-All. Afterward, I learned from the manufacturer—Elmer’s Products Inc. (a division of Borden, Inc.)—that their glue was introduced in 1947 under the brand name Coscorez. In 1951 its packaging was changed and the product was renamed for its then-new marketing symbol, Elmer the bull. The glue’s current composition is virtually identical to that of the original 1947 product. Upon

---

*Robert A. Galganski has a master’s degree in civil engineering and is employed as a ground vehicle crash safety systems research and development specialist. He recently received the Ufologist of the Year award at the 1997 National UFO Conference in Springfield, Ohio, for his contributions to Roswell Incident research.*

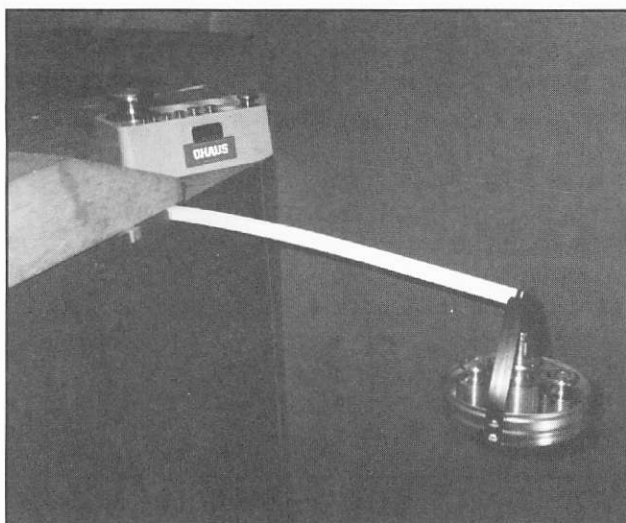


Figure 1. Bending- and shear-strength test setup.

drying, a coating of this white-colored liquid changes into a clear (transparent) film.

But I also found out that Elmer's Glue is and always was a water-based polyvinyl-acetate-type adhesive—which contains no casein. So Moore's description, strictly speaking, is contradictory. Consequently, it's not certain whether a casein or a polyvinyl-acetate glue was used with the 1947 rawlin target struts.

To account for both possibilities I ran a third series of experiments which replicated the others—this time with a casein glue made by the National Casein Company. National Casein, which has been making casein and resin products since 1919, sent me a sample of aircraft-grade 8580 Casein Glue, their best product. According to Ken Blake of the company's New Jersey branch, its strength is comparable to the highest-quality casein glue available in the mid 1940s.

National Casein 8580 Glue is a water-based, ivory-colored liquid (after mixing—see next section). A surface coated with it has a translucent appearance when dry.

**Material preparation.** Moore wasn't sure if the glue was merely brushed on the sticks or if they were soaked—full-strength or diluted (presumably with water)—in the glue. For the second (Elmer's Glue) test series I selected an all-glue, full-immersion pan soak in order to maximize the assumed beneficial effects of the treatment. The specimens were submerged—individually—in the glue for 20 minutes, removed, and allowed to dry. Because of some distractions during this time, some sticks stayed in the bath a few minutes longer than the others.

During my conversation with Ken Blake I learned that a wood's strength isn't influenced very much by whether or how glue has been applied to it—a full soak or merely brushed on its surface. Both techniques provide mostly a mechanical attachment of the glue to the surface of the wood—as with paint; very little glue impregnation occurs. Without pressure treatment per se—e.g., where a material

such as a preservative is literally forced into the cells of an outdoors-use-type wood—the glue penetrates only several fibers deep below the surface. (I subsequently evaluated Blake's statement by experiment. See the Beam Strength and Other Tests section below.)

Since I had soaked the Elmer's Glue-treated specimens, I had no choice but to prepare the casein-glue-treated sticks in the same manner.

All of National Casein's glues come in a dry powder form and require mixing with water according to a specified procedure. These instructions were followed explicitly during glue preparation. To eliminate the above-noted soak time variability, I immersed all sticks en masse for 20 minutes in the resulting full-strength liquid product.

After all glue-treated sticks were removed from their bath, their surfaces were brushed with additional adhesive during the initial drying stage in an attempt to give them a uniform and drip-free coating. As a result, a relatively thick film covered the wood.

**Balsa wood revisited.** All raw wood test specimens and those soaked in Elmer's Glue were purchased in July 1997; they were subsequently employed in the first two series of experiments performed in early October 1997. The third and final series of tests—those using casein glue—were conducted in early December and used wood purchased a couple of weeks earlier. Given the high volume of business the hobby store does, it's possible that the latter batch of sticks came from a different shipment. Consequently, some of the wood physical properties such as bending and shear strength *could* have been different from those characterizing the earlier group. The extent of such possible disparities—which may have been well within the envelope of variability normally displayed by all woods—is uncertain.

## COLOR, SURFACE LUSTER, AND TEXTURE

Obviously, raw wood will look and feel different compared to wood that has a coating of dried glue on it. How much so depends on a number of factors such as the type of wood and its exposed grain pattern, type of glue used, and the number of coatings applied.

When wet, both adhesive coatings obscured the balsa wood's natural tan color and grain pattern. But when completely dry its distinguishing characteristics were once again visible. The Elmer's Glue-treated pieces were shinier and felt smoother than raw wood; their casein-glue-treated counterparts felt rougher and had a slightly yellow cast and "frosty" appearance. But in both cases the treated specimens *still looked like wood*.

## BEAM STRENGTH AND OTHER TESTS

Since wood has a cellular structure whose outer fibers can absorb liquid, some of its physical properties can undoubtedly be altered by immersing it in or coating it with glue. But could a dry, thin shell of glue *significantly* increase the

**TABLE 1**  
**Transverse Force Required to Break Balsa-Wood Struts**

| Balsa-Wood<br>Test Specimen<br>Condition  | Breaking Force for Specimen (in newtons) |      |      |      |      | Average<br>Breaking Force<br>(newtons) |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|------|------|------|------|----------------------------------------|
|                                           | A                                        | B    | C    | D    | E    |                                        |
| Raw                                       | 10.0                                     | 6.0  | 6.9  | 6.7  | —    | 7.4                                    |
| Soaked in<br>Elmer's Glue-All             | 4.7                                      | 4.0  | 4.2  | —    | —    | 4.3                                    |
| Soaked in<br>National Casein<br>8580 Glue | 21.2                                     | 19.2 | 15.4 | 15.3 | 16.0 | 17.4                                   |

*Note: 1 newton = 0.2248 pound.*

bending and shear resistance of balsa wood—an inherently weak material—especially since, as noted earlier, most of the applied substance merely resides on the surface? The following tests were performed to provide a quantitative answer to that question.

As shown in Figure 1, struts were secured to the top surface of a workbench by means of a carpenter's wooden clamp. This setup constitutes a cantilever beam configuration; the beam is fully restrained at its single support location. Three series of replicate tests with raw and glue-treated sticks were run. Known masses were systematically and gently placed in a metal pan suspended at the free end of each strut 10 inches (254 mm) from the fixed support. They generated a static (i.e., slowly applied) load perpendicular to the beam longitudinal axis. The cumulative applied force acting on the beam was recorded until the beam began—with an audible “crack”—to break.

As expected, all struts broke at the fixed support. Maximum free-end beam deflection just prior to failure, measured relative to the original horizontal orientation, ranged from about two to three inches (51 to 76 mm). That's a lot of deformation in a short (10-inch) span. Of the three wood specimen conditions examined, the casein-glue-treated beams bent the most.

The persons who handled the debris-field struts reported that they were only *slightly* flexible.

Table 1 documents the magnitude of the force at which each strut failed. None could sup-

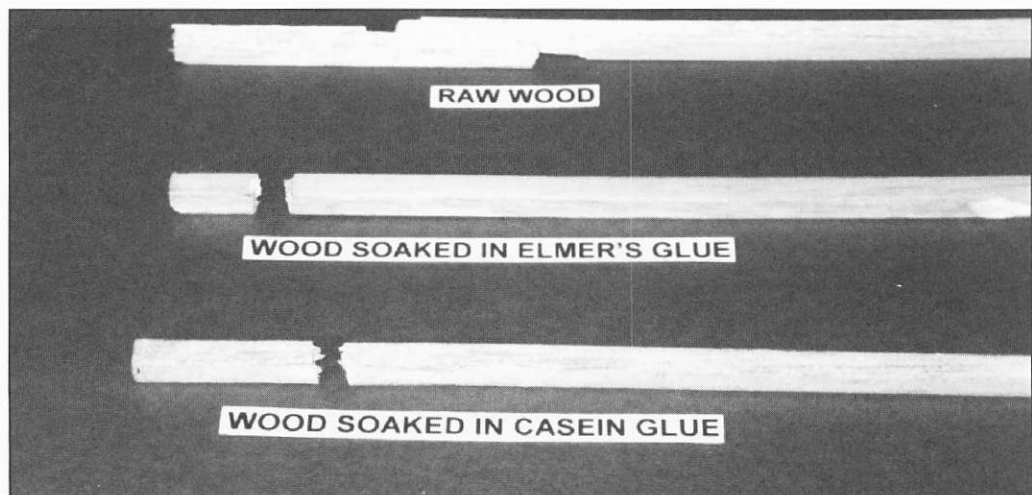
port more than 21.2 newtons (less than five pounds). *Anybody* can apply such a force with a finger.

The data scatter present for each wood condition reflects the effects of such factors as nonhomogeneous wood composition, the probable small variation in beam cantilever length and force location relative to the fixed support, as well as slight differences in glue soak time and/or glue film thickness.

All beams soaked in Elmer's Glue-All failed at a *lower* force level (average force equal to 4.3 newtons) than their untreated counterparts (7.4 newtons)—a strength reduction of more than 40%.

The beams soaked in National Casein 8580 Glue exhibited the opposite effect. Their average breaking force was 17.4 newtons, about two and one-half and four times higher than the levels reached with the raw wood and Elmer's Glue-soaked wood, respectively. However, as noted earlier, they could *still* be easily broken by hand.

Blake's contention that soaking or coating the wood with glue would not significantly affect its strength was



*Figure 2. Typical condition of balsa-wood struts following beam- strength testing.*

evaluated during the final test series. I applied a single coat of casein glue to one strut and allowed it to dry. When loaded, it broke at 16.9 newtons, very representative of the 17.4-newton average failure force level exhibited by the five casein-glue-soaked beam samples. He was right.

Two different beam failure modes were observed. All glue-soaked struts exhibited a classic pure-bending stress-type failure shown in Figure 2: a somewhat jagged but primarily vertical break confined to the support. The raw wood struts failed due to a combination of bending and horizontal shear stress, producing a long, diagonal break that extended away from the support along the length of the beam.

The internal wood fibers projecting from the broken end surfaces of all struts were obvious; they could be seen and felt. If the struts found on the debris field were indeed made of wood, eyewitnesses should have been able to identify them as such—simply by looking at them.

Nobody ever mentioned seeing this definitive broken-wood signature on the debris-field strut fragments.

Intuitively, the contention that a wimpy stick of balsa wood can be rendered unbreakable by coating it with glue is patently absurd. This gut feeling is supported by basic beam theory. It clearly indicates that a beam having the material and geometric properties of a raw-in-target strut will

easily break under extremely low-magnitude transverse loading.

The wood's paltry bending and shear resistance can be increased *somewhat* by turning it into a composite beam—for example, by bonding a thin layer of modern high-strength (and in this case, lightweight) material such as 7075-T6 aluminum alloy to its surfaces.

A coating of glue simply won't work. And the skeptics haven't—as yet, anyway—claimed that the sticks were actually some U.S. top-secret, super-high-strength material laminate unistrut.

I avoided all the nerdy engineering theory for my readers and cut directly to the chase by doing the tests described above. The results showed conclusively that the struts recovered from the debris field had to be fashioned from some extremely lightweight material substantially stronger than raw or glue-treated balsa wood.

Skeptics might suggest that stiffness should be tested.

Stiffness, defined in terms of a force per unit length or moment (a force times the perpendicular distance between its line of application and the axis of rotation) per unit rotation, typically describes a material's resistance to elastic deformation, i.e., deformation fully recoverable upon removal of the loading. It has nothing to do with its breaking or ultimate strength.

Two other types of experiments were conducted to assess the purported enhanced burn

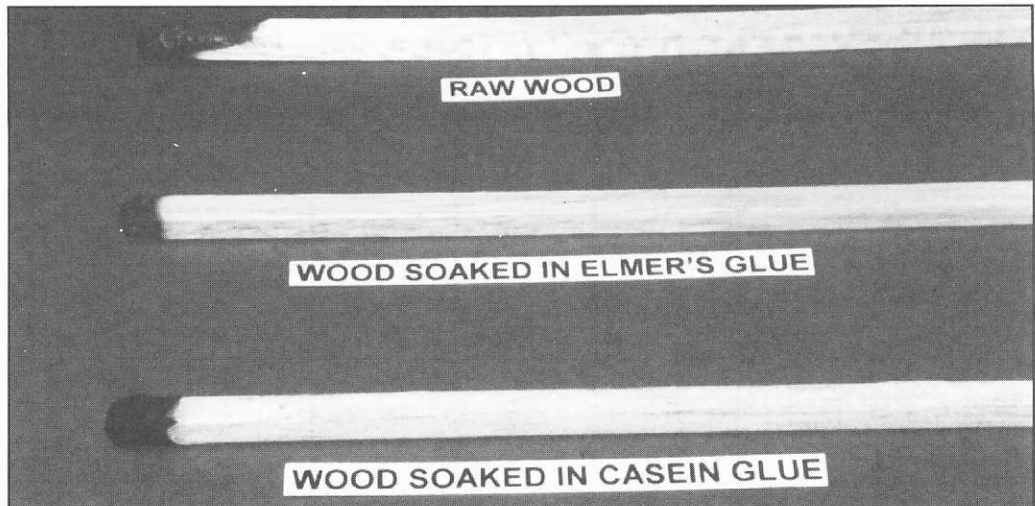


Figure 3. Condition of struts after combustibility testing.

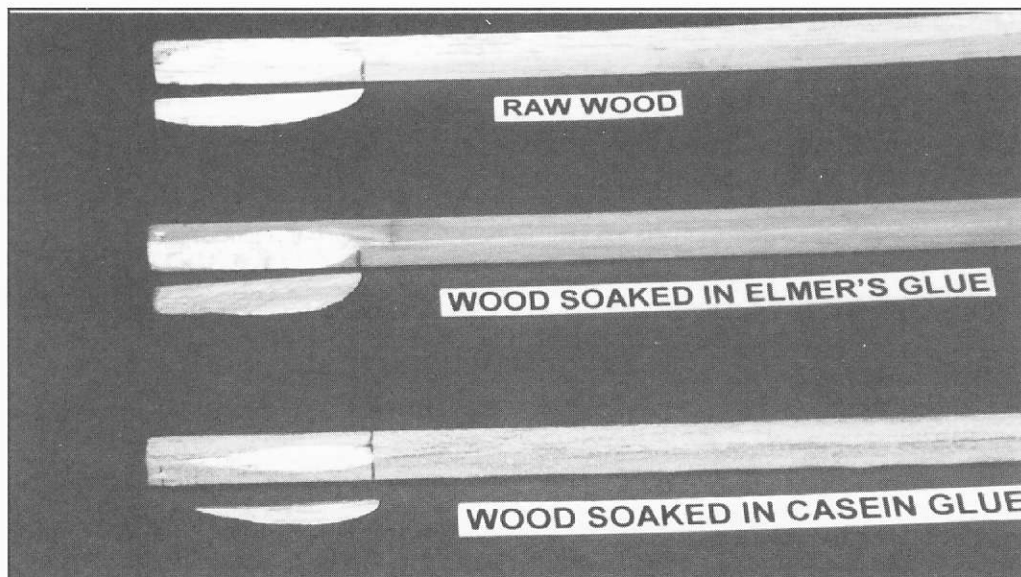


Figure 4. Condition of struts after cut-resistance testing.

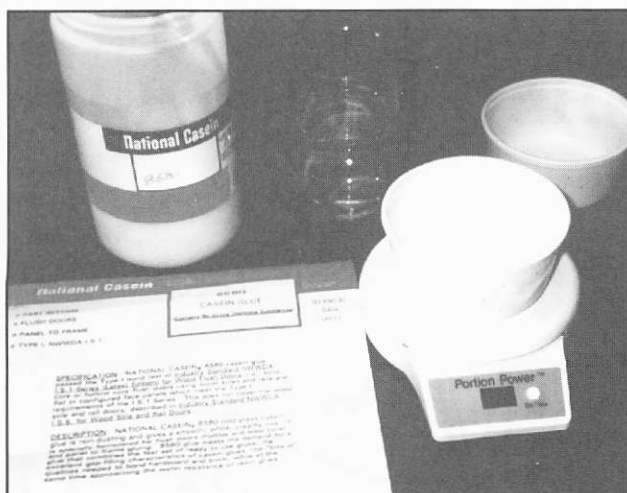


Figure 5. Casein glue and specs, with digital scale used to prepare glue.

and cut resistance of glue-treated balsa wood. Although the protocols employed were not as rigorous as those involved in the beam-response evaluations, they provided vital information needed to make at least a qualitative evaluation of those claims.

**Combustibility.** The ends of all three wood specimen types were exposed to a 20-second continuous burn from a lighter flame. The significant result: Both glue-treated struts caught fire and burned—not as quickly or as extensively as the raw wood (see Figure 3), but they *did* succumb to the flame. Since the treated specimens actually burned, the noncombustible struts found at the debris field had to be something other than balsa wood treated with a polyvinyl-acetate-type or casein-type glue.

**Cut resistance.** This was the least rigorous experiment performed. I used a new knife blade each time in an attempt to remove a two-inch long, roughly triangular cross-sectioned piece from the edge of all three specimen types (see Figure 4). As best as I could determine (feel), the raw wood provided just as much resistance—very little—to the blade as did the Elmer's Glue-treated wood.

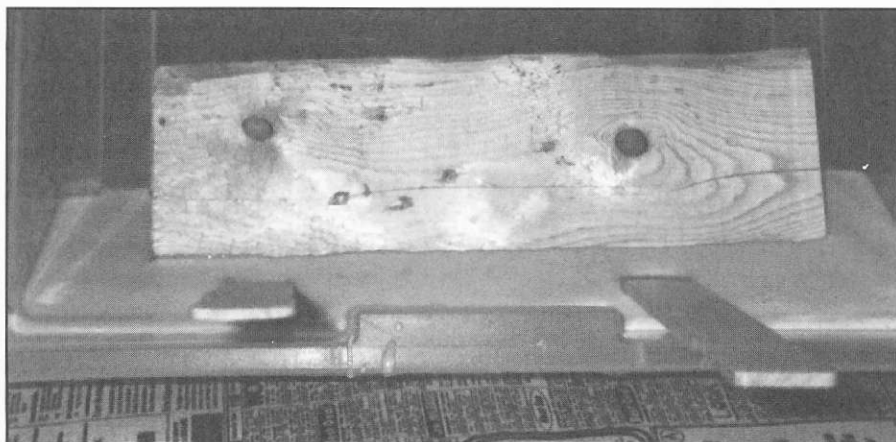


Figure 7. Balsa wood sticks in casein-glue bath, held down by two larger pieces of wood and a 2x4.

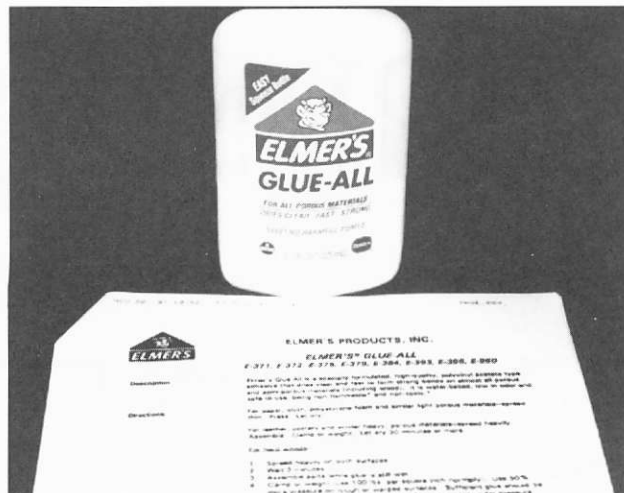


Figure 6. Elmer's Glue-All and instruction sheets.

The specimen treated with the casein product was a bit more difficult to slice, as evidenced by the smaller piece displayed in Figure 4. But I was *still* able to whittle it.

Because they couldn't be cut (period), the thin-strut fragments found on the debris field were not made from balsa wood.

## SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

Roswell skeptics suggest that the unusual thin-strut fragments found on the Foster ranch debris field were merely casein-glue-treated balsa-wood wreckage from Project Mogul Flight 4. This claim—typical of the broad and often vague pontification that pervades ufology—is unsupported by any substantive evidence.

In this case, skeptics could have easily tested the “glue hypothesis” as I call it—but didn't. Perhaps their usual knee-jerk response—denial—to a potentially unsettling alternate explanation prevented them from even considering a scientific approach. I did.

I performed a series of straightforward and simple tests

that provided unambiguous empirical data. The results led to an inescapable conclusion: The struts, which reportedly exhibited extraordinary physical properties atypical of late 1940s technology, could *not* have been made from balsa wood. This means that they could not have been components from a Mogul balloon train, which leaves no other conventional explanations that have not already been eliminated.

As such, an extraterrestrial origin for the struts and other debris-field material must still be considered a viable possibility. ♦

# UFO CRASH AT SHAG HARBOUR

BY DON LEDGER

**C**ould Be Something Concrete in Shag Harbour UFO—RCAF,” the headline declared. Using letters one inch high, the *Halifax Herald* for October 6, 1967, informed its readers that two days earlier a UFO had crashed into the waters off Shag Harbour, Nova Scotia, on the eastern coast of Canada.

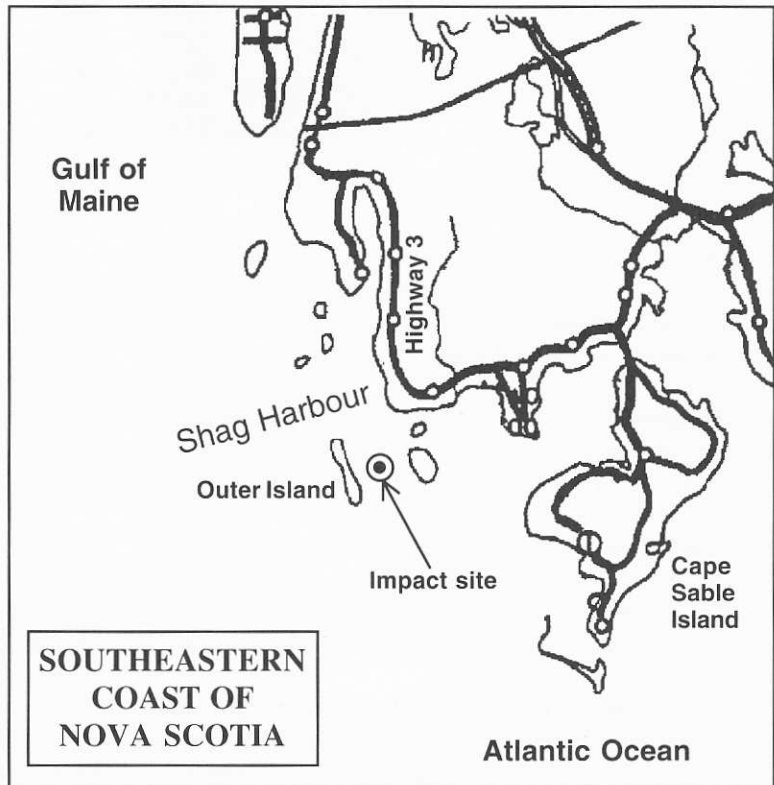
As those of us that live here can attest, this was a startling headline for what was and still is a very conservative, provincially circulated, daily newspaper. The *Herald* informed the public that Laurie Wickens, the first of 11 people, had reported to the RCMP detachment in Barrington Passage, Shelburne County, on Nova Scotia's south shore that an airliner or airplane had crashed offshore late on the evening of October 4.

Wickens and four of his friends were driving through the village of Shag Harbour on Highway 3 at a few minutes after 11:00 p.m. ADT when they spotted something unusual above and in front of their car. A large object flashing four sequential amber-colored lights descended at a modest rate of speed at an angle of approximately 45 degrees. From their vantage point it looked like the object was going to go down into the waters of the harbor.

Wickens endeavored to keep the object in sight while he drove his vehicle through the village and westward to the other side, whereupon at this point the UFO disappeared behind some trees and a small hill. It was only a matter of seconds before he rounded a turn from behind the hill which brought him right up to the shore of the Sound, a body of water adjacent to Shag Harbour.

Wickens drove onto the graveled shoreside parking lot of an Irish Moss plant. The five witnesses sprang from their car, ran to the water's edge, and stood watching a “dark object” floating or hovering just above the water. The

*Don Ledger is a UFO researcher living in Bedford, Nova Scotia and employed by the Nova Scotia government as the director/coordinator of the Legislative Television coverage of the debates in the Nova Scotia legislature, and other related production work.*



flashing lights had extinguished to be replaced with one pale, constant yellow light that seemed to be on top of the object located about 800–900 feet from their position and drifting with the ebb tide. Records show and the witnesses stated that the night was cool and extremely clear with no moon. The winds were calm and the sky a blanket of stars.

Laurie Wickens's friends were as excited as he was. Concerned, they debated for a moment what to do. Wickens decided finally that rather than drive 10 miles back to the RCMP detachment in Barrington Passage or wake up someone in the village, he would go a short distance west to the village of Wood's Harbour and use a pay telephone at a gas station. There he contacted RCMP Corporal Werbicki and reported that he saw a big airplane or small airliner crash into the Sound next to the harbor.

The 18-year-old fisherman was surprised when Werbicki asked him if he had been drinking. Wickens denied this and was then told to hang up but to remain by the pay phone.

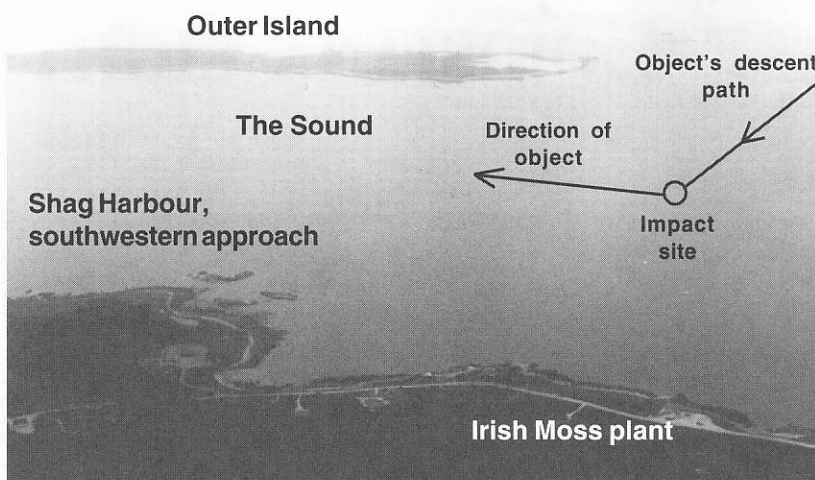
Werbicki had a couple of constables over in that area

and was about to contact them by radio when his phone rang once more and he was informed by Mary Banks on Maggie Garron's Point, an area adjoining the Sound and Prospect Point at the western end of Shag Harbour, that she saw an airplane crash into the Sound. That was enough for Werbicki. He contacted his constables, Ron O'Brien and Ron Pond and ordered them back to the detachment. Two more calls came in, one from a man in nearby Bear Point and another from two women over on Cape Sable Island 13 miles away, claiming she and another woman had seen the same thing. The man in Bear Point claimed he heard a whistle and a bang. Earlier, one of Wickens's companions said she heard a whistling noise and a whoosh. Corporal Werbicki called Wickens back, asking him to meet him and the other Mounties at the Moss Plant.

Shortly before Laurie Wickens and his friends pursued the object through the village of Shag Harbour, two 18-year-old fishermen a few miles to the east of Shag Harbour were returning from a date with their girlfriends on Cape Sable Island. They had just entered a portion of Highway 3 that runs across the base of Bear Point when the passenger, Norman Smith, pointed out to the driver, David Kendrick, an unusual object in the night sky hanging at a 45-degree angle pointing down toward Shag Harbour. They noted four to five amber or orange-colored lights flashing sequentially and what for a moment Norm thought might be the windows of an airliner. Dave Kendrick had to satisfy himself with only occasional glimpses of the object while driving along a narrow, twisting, and hilly road bordered on either side by gnarled and stunted spruce trees blasted by years of nor'easters. They soon lost sight of the object behind the tree line in the direction of Shag Harbour some two miles distant.

Minutes later Kendrick dropped Smith off at his house and left, eager to get home to bed because he had an early start the next morning. However, Smith was walking toward the house when he spotted the object again, this time nearly down to the harbor. He ran inside and pulled his father Wifred out to the front yard. He was in time to observe the object drop behind a small hill a short distance away. He agreed with Smith that it must have gone down into the harbor and they decided to go there to see if there was anything they could do. Both men were sure it was an airliner in distress. Wifred hurried back inside to get dressed.

The distance between Highway 3 and the shoreline of the Sound at the Irish Moss plant is about 100 feet and affords an unobstructed view out into the Sound to the south. It is bounded on the left by Maggie Garron's Point and Prospect Point and to right by the Outer Island, a three-mile long by quarter-mile wide strip of rock and sand covered with spruce trees and marsh grass. Between the two



*The Sound off Shag Harbour and the impact point.*

shores is the body of water, known as the Sound, about two miles wide and four miles long and open to the Atlantic Ocean. Drifting placidly upon the Sound on a gentle swell about 1200 feet from the Moss plant and a quarter-mile east of Outer Island, was a dark object.

Wickens and his friends stood once more on the shore and watched it. Moments later, two RCMP cruisers crunched onto the gravel parking lot followed shortly after by Norm and Wifred Smith in their pickup. Everyone stood and watched for a moment. Werbicki had to have the object pointed out to him by Wickens, but eventually he too spotted the pale yellow light on the craft and the dark area below it, which he figured was about 60 feet wide. Norm Smith estimated the height of the object to be about 10 feet by measuring it against the height of a buoy called the Budget Light nearby.

Now that he could see it with his own eyes, Werbicki was concerned for survivors who might either be on the object or in the water. He gave orders for Constable Pond to start taking statements and to keep an eye on the light. He ordered Constable O'Brien to go to one of the houses nearby, contact by telephone the Rescue Coordination Center in Halifax, advise them of the situation, and ask them to try and determine what aircraft might have gone in the waters here or if any were missing. In the meantime, he was going to another house and call two of the local fishermen who had their own boats and get someone out there as soon as possible. But before they could leave, one of the witnesses yelled that it was going down.

Everybody turned their attention to the dark object. It evidently was slipping under the waters of the Sound. The pale-yellow light extinguished and the object disappeared from sight. Only five or six minutes had passed, barely enough time to react, and now there was no time left. Werbicki and O'Brien left the area to carry out their tasks.

Bradford Shand and Lawrence Smith, Norman Smith's

*(continued on page 20)*

# LOUISIANA LIGHTS IN 1967

BY JOHN O. WILLIAMS

**M**ore than 20 years have passed since the incidents I am about to describe, but in all that time I have been unable to come up with a reasonable explanation for them. I hope that some insights may be forthcoming from readers of *IUR*.

As I recall, the incidents took place on a spring evening in 1967 in Shreveport, Louisiana. I was an instructor in the Mathematics Department of Centenary College at that time. On the evening in question, I had taken my freshman astronomy class, numbering about 25 students, into an open field on campus where they could have an unobstructed view of the night sky. My intention was to point out a number of constellations and, further, to remain there long enough for the students to perceive the nightly motion of the sky due to the Earth's rotation. It was a perfect, clear night for observing. There was no moon.

Curiously, the subject of UFOs had come up in the classroom prior to this observing session and, jokingly, I had offered an extra-credit "A" to the first student who could spot one while we were in the field. It never once occurred to me that I might actually have to pay off!

We had been talking about constellations for about a half-hour when one of my students suddenly blurted out, "Hey, Mr. Williams, I get that extra-credit 'A.' There's a UFO!" I turned to see what he was talking about and saw a bright orange light almost precisely due west of us at an elevation of about 30 degrees.

It was approaching at a modest angular rate of perhaps one degree per second. In astronomical terms, its brightness was somewhere between that of Jupiter and Venus. My first reaction was that it was only an airplane, and I said as much.

"But why don't we hear it?" came another student's query. "It's still too far away," I replied. "Wait until it gets overhead."

Everyone's attention was now focused on the silently approaching light and astronomy, for the moment, was completely forgotten. In a short time, the light neared our zenith heading due east and it became apparent to us that there was a second light, much fainter and blue in color, that was directly behind the orange light and following it in



*Figure 1. The orange light and its trailing thread of blue light.*

perfect synchronization. I believed I had the explanation for these lights. "Do you see that blue light?" I said. "That must be on the tail of the aircraft, while the orange light is on the nose." No sooner had I said this, than the blue light separated from its aft position, performed a tight turn southward and proceeded down our celestial meridian until it was lost from view. No one said anything for a moment. Finally, I said, "That's probably an air refueling operation." This made sense to me, since we were not many miles from a Strategic Air Command base, Barksdale AFB in Bossier City, Louisiana. (Some months later I had the opportunity to discuss this incident with Dr. J. Allen Hynek, and he informed me that what we had seen couldn't have been an air refueling operation, because such operations at night were so hazardous that they were always extremely well lit. We would have seen far more illumination than two simple lights, one orange and one blue.)

As for the orange light, it continued eastward for a time, then performed a very tight 180-degree turn and came back over us. Accelerating to more than twice its former angular rate, it headed due west and eventually faded from view. No sound was ever heard during this sequence of events, although the turns executed by both lights didn't seem beyond the capability of conventional aircraft.

I tried to bring the class focus back onto astronomy and, briefly, I was successful. But after only 20 minutes had passed, we were interrupted once more. "Mr. Williams, there's that UFO again!" said yet another student.

*John O. Williams is an assistant professor in the Physics and Astronomy department at the University of Arkansas at Little Rock and director of its planetarium.*

"Where?" I asked. Everyone followed the direction he was pointing, just above the horizon and slightly north of due east. There, moving slowly southward at an elevation of about five degrees, was what certainly appeared to be a reincarnation of the orange light we had seen earlier. However, this time it was not followed by a blue light, but by what seemed to be a thread of blue light (Figure 1). And the thread was rippling, much like the appearance of moonlight over water. I thought quickly, and came up with what seemed to me to be a reasonable explanation. "I do know what that is," I said. "That's an advertising plane towing an electric sign, but we can't read the sign at this distance." No sooner had I said this, than the "thread" of blue light broke up into seven or eight individual blue lights, which took their leave in every which direction. Some moved off horizontally, while others went straight up. One or two even followed a zigzag path as they rose and gradually faded into the darkness (Figure 2).

My confidence in my ability to identify objects in the sky was greatly shaken.

To this day I feel that these incidents may have a prosaic explanation. After all, there was a SAC base in the

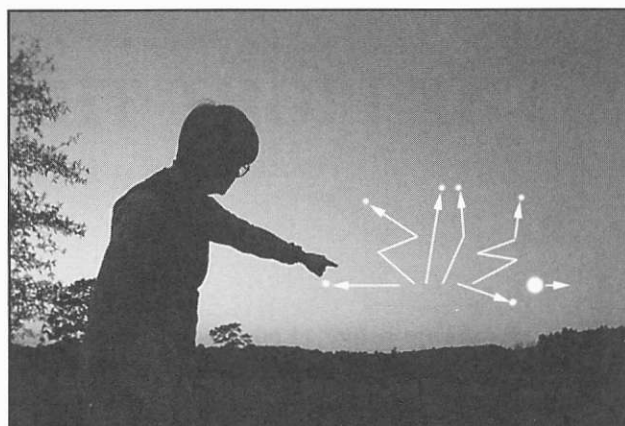


Figure 2. The subsequent dispersion of the thread.

area and the movements were not obviously unconventional (no right-angle turns, stops, sudden reversals of direction, etc.).

The lack of sound, however, remains disconcerting. If any readers know of a conventional explanation for nocturnal lights that behave such as these did, I would welcome their response. ♦

## SCIENTIFIC PANEL: UFO EVIDENCE BEARS INVESTIGATION

There may be more to UFO evidence than just verbal reports of what people see in the sky. Some UFO evidence may be worthy of scientific investigation. This is the tentative conclusion of a panel of scientists convened by the Society for Scientific Exploration to examine this matter.

The panel of nine scientists met at a conference center near New York from September 29 to October 3, 1997.

The panel reviewed evidence presented by eight UFO investigators, and will issue a report within a few months that summarizes the workshop activities and makes recommendations for further research. Panelists were drawn from France, Germany, and the United States. Investigators came from France, Germany, Norway, and the United States.

The strong representation from France is due to the fact that France is the only country that has an unclassified ongoing official investigation into UFO reports. This program, headquartered at the French Space Agency (CNES) in Toulouse, is headed by Jean-Jacques Velasco, a participant in the workshop.

Velasco described damage to soil and vegetation associated with a strange object that was seen to land at a farm in Trans-en-Provence in France, departing within about one minute. This evidence has been analyzed by scientists in France on behalf of CNES.

Other evidence presented and critically reviewed at the workshop included photographs, video records, spectroscopic data, radar records, reports of malfunctions of automobile and aircraft equipment, material specimens, and radiation-type injuries to witnesses.

"We made no effort to solve the UFO problem," said Von Eshleman of Stanford University and Thomas Holzer of the High Altitude Observatory, coauthors of the review panel. "We had a far more modest goal. We were here only to inform ourselves about claimed evidence, and to try to decide if further scientific study of such evidence is likely to significantly advance the resolution of the UFO problem."

The "UFO problem" was defined by Peter Sturrock of Stanford University, director of the workshop, as the problem of understanding the cause or causes of UFO reports.

"Honest people report strange observations. Not all reports have obvious explanations. So what are the not-so-obvious explanations? I would like to see scientists play a more active role in helping to unravel this 50-year-old mystery. I see the workshop as a small step in this direction."

Other members of the panel were Randy Jokipii of the University of Arizona, François Louange from France, Jay Melosh of the University of Arizona, James Papike of the University of New Mexico, Guenther Reitz from Germany, Charles Tolbert from the University of Virginia, and Bernard Veyret from France.

In addition to Velasco, the panel received presentations from Richard Haines of Los Altos, California; Illobrand von Ludwiger of Germany; Mark Rodeghier of Chicago; John Schuessler of Houston; Erling Strand of Norway; Michael Swords of Kalamazoo, Michigan; and Jacques Vallee of San Francisco. ♦

---

# THE LIGHT THAT STOPPED A CAR

BY CLAS SVAHN AND JÖRGEN GRANLIE

**I**t was shortly before 11.00 p.m. on February 15, 1994. Kerstin Hallman had finished her work at the Fagerudd Conference Center to the south of Enköping, Sweden (80 km northwest of Stockholm). It was a clear and calm winter night and 12 degrees below zero on the centigrade scale. Hallman started her Volvo 245 to drive 20 kilometers to her home at Grillby. As always, she took the small road through Boglösa and Villberga instead of the E18 highway. The moon had just passed below the horizon but the snow cover still made the road bright and easy to observe.

I was going at about 60–70 kilometers because the road was rather slippery. As I was a few kilometers from home there was a sudden brightness and I looked up.

Over a group of trees on my right side I saw a very oblong light that had “spikes” on the upper part. Just as I spotted this light the car started to act irregularly. I looked at the dashboard and noted that the car lights grew weaker and the speedometer went down. When I looked up on the road again—I had to bend forwards—the light took off and it just disappeared. The light was yellow, almost like from a candle light. Very yellow. The car continued some 100–200 meters while the lights grew dimmer and dimmer and finally it stopped. It was completely dead.

Hallman managed to roll the car to the side of the road and wait for help. A few minutes later a milk truck came by. The driver stopped to help her, but he did not succeed in starting her car. Instead, he called Hallman’s husband on the phone and asked him to come and help her.

As my husband sat down at the wheel and turned the ignition key it started with no trouble at all. He managed at the very first attempt.

Her husband tells us he was very surprised when the compartment light lit up as he opened the door and yet more surprised when the car started so easily.

But next day it was completely dead. I took the battery out and had it checked and loaded at a service station. It was faultless.

---

*Clas Svahn is director of UFO-Sweden and its extensive UFO Library, the Archives of UFO Research, in Norrköping, Sweden. Jörgen Granlie is a regional director for UFO-Sweden and an expert on UFO databases.*

A few days after the incident, UFO-Sweden paid for a new checkup of Hallman’s car, especially with a view of finding out if there was something wrong with the electrical system. No faults were found. The car, a 1983 model, has a conventional ignition and carburetor system without sensitive electronic equipment. Ice formation in the carburetor could result in engine failure in this type of car but after a few minutes it will usually start up again. Such a failure would not have any influence on the lights, however.

Another possibility would be that the ignition voltage from the generator was somehow disrupted. Such a failure would not, however, have any large influence on the car’s operation in the short distance in question.

UFO-Sweden has also tried to find an explanation for the light Hallman saw. A number of possible airports and helicopter owners were checked but none reported any activity.

“I sometimes ponder over what it was that I saw but I just don’t know,” said Hallman. “It resembled an oblong football with spires turned upwards, fantastically bright. More I wouldn’t know.”

“Are you convinced that there was a connection between the light and the car failure?” she was asked.

“I can’t imagine anything else. It never happened either before or since that the car has stopped in this way. There must have been a connection.”

Steve Sandström, chairman of UFO-Skellefteå, and a member of one of UFO-Sweden’s assessment groups, cautions us to be careful in our judgment. He remembers a similar incident, without any light phenomena, that he experienced while driving a Volvo Amazon car. “Suddenly the car started to go heavy, the engine seemed tortured, and the car’s lighting (even the lights inside) started to glow a pale yellow. It was as if someone had connected a two-ton trailer to the back of the car. Then suddenly the phenomenon released its grip on the car, and everything was normal. When the interested owner of the Volvo Amazon finally found the fault it turned out to be a loose contact in the generator that caused a short-circuit.”

Now this explanation is far from applicable to this case. The battery in Hallman’s Volvo was in good shape and the car had started with no problem just ten minutes before the incident. A loose generator would have no effect on the car since there was power from the battery. It hasn’t been possible to find any reasonable explanation for the incident. ♦

---

# OUT OF THE SKY?

## A CURIOUS STORY OF 1911

BY ELSIE SHIRLEY

*Editor's note: What follows is a slightly edited version of a letter written to J. Allen Hynek on November 24, 1973. The writer, then 77 years old, lived in Marysville, Ohio.*

**I**n May 1911, my sister Idella, age 36, and her two sons, 10 and 12 years old, were living in Piqua, Ohio, in a large house a quarter of a mile or more outside the city limits and the nearest house to the north. On the other sides the house was surrounded by a large area of farmlands. These were crossed far to the south by a railroad, where a new bridge was in the process of being constructed.

From a visit my mother and I had during the previous holidays, I vaguely remember that the house had been rented and my sister engaged by the railroad to furnish board and room for the out-of-town contractors who were supervising the project. At the time of our visit, we found my sister content and happy with her work.

About the middle of May, my sister traveled the Erie Express to Broadway, Union County, Ohio, around noon. My grandmother resided across the highway from the depot, and my sister went to her home. This vicinity had been the home of our family since the early 1800s, but my mother, a widow of 13 years, had bought a home and moved 14 miles east to Delaware County earlier in March.

A phone call to my mother informed her that my sister had arrived in a state of physical and mental distress. Immediately my mother and middle brother started with horse and buggy to Broadway. Concerned about my sister's two young boys, my youngest brother hopped a freight train (for the first and last time in his life) and rode the rails to Piqua.

There he learned from the hired men that in the morning, prior to her train trip, Idella had been her usual cheerful and capable self. The boys said their mother had sent them off to school around 8:30 a.m. and seemed all right.

But what happened between 8:30 and 11:15 when she had to get on a train to catch the Erie Express at Peoria, the next station west of Broadway, where the two railroads crossed?

Meanwhile, Dr. Jenkins, my grandmother's next-door neighbor, had contacted my oldest brother, Dr. D. C. Fox of Kenton, Ohio, and some county official for consultation. When they examined Idella, they found that her face was seared, not burned, to the approximate color of a paper

grocery sack. Her tongue was swollen badly, and the only thing she could swallow was liquor. The most puzzling symptom was that just below the largest part of the calf of the legs were creases deep enough to encase three fingers held closely together—fore, big, and ring—in the indentation.

Worst of all, however, was the damage to her mind. Though rational on other subjects, Idella grew frightened and incoherent when asked what had happened to her. The examiners were sure her legs had not been tied with rope such as was in use on most farms. It had to have been of some smoother material, they said.

Eighteen months of trauma and distress followed. Idella and her two sons moved in with us in our home in Delaware, Ohio. We were a new family in a tightly knit community not entirely welcoming of strangers, so there was much gossip concerning the "crazy woman."

My sister's expressed determination to end her life meant that we had to watch her all the time. Once a brother stopped her from throwing herself from a very high beam in the barn onto heavy farm implements. Another time my mother pulled her from the Scioto River, then had to nurse her through pneumonia.

Finally, in February 1912, Idella was committed to the state hospital in Columbus. Though under constant surveillance, she finally managed to kill herself, in the middle of the night the following November, by jumping out a window.

### LOOKING BACK

Her death closed a sad chapter in our lives, and we rarely spoke of it again. Years later, when I began reading books on UFOs, I thought about it again. I remembered something she had said to us.

One night in our kitchen, as Idella stood with one hand on the old cistern pump and the other on my mother's shoulder, she spoke with great earnestness of how "they" had come out of the sky; they were going to destroy all of us and take her boys and my mother's boys.

After World War I my brother and I recalled her words. He thought that in some way she had foreseen bombing by airplanes. She knew nothing of airplanes. Country people in

*(continued on page 27)*

# TULLY SAUCER NESTS OF 1966— PART ONE

BY BILL CHALKER

**T**he Tully “saucer nest” has a very special place in UFO lore. The famous Tully “UFO nest” affair of 1966 is one of the best-known accounts of an apparent UFO landing report. It forms a very important nexus in the pivotal question of UFO reality.

1966 was a major year for UFO activity in Australia. The classic UFO landing at Horseshoe Lagoon near Tully in far north Queensland was witnessed by 28-year-old banana farmer George Pedley and entered the term UFO “nest” into popular UFO parlance. The locality was the center of an extended UFO milieu that continued for many years, particularly in 1969, 1972, and 1975. The area was also the site of controversial experiments in UFO detection through remote sensing and filming.

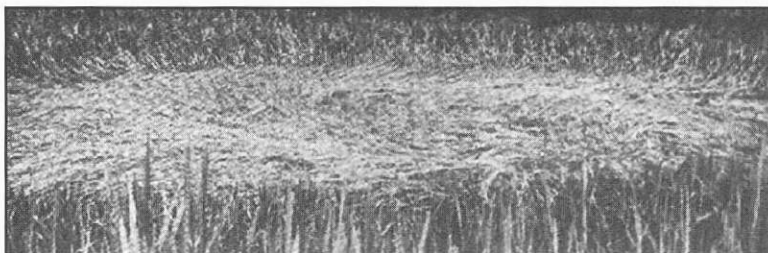
The Tully incident has been mentioned extensively in the UFO literature over the years, and yet surprisingly many inaccuracies and misconceptions have developed. These problems became more critical when the famous incident once again became the focus of attention, this time due to the English crop-circle controversy.

The prominent schools of thought on the crop-circle formations adopted the 1966 Tully incident as a classic example of their perceived explanations for the circle complexes. Their claims about the relevance of the Tully incident as the progenitor or a classic example of the currently perceived crop-circle phenomenon were flawed and generally unfounded. Doug and Dave, the notorious “circle” hoaxers, also cited the Tully incident as the inspiration of their crop-circle creation escapades.

But instead of being an example of a wind-vortex effect, spaceship landing site, the result of occult paranormal forces, “plasma vortex” evidence, or hoaxed saucer nest, the Pedley nest is a remarkable example of a UFO physical-trace case. The choice of UFO is deliberate, in that an unidentified phenomenon was apparently involved and a definitive explanation currently eludes us.

---

*Bill Chalker, an IUR contributing editor, is one of Australia's leading researchers and coordinates the New South Wales UFO Investigation Centre (UFOIC). His book The Oz Files was published in 1996 by Duffy and Snellgrove.*



*Original Tully “saucer nest” at Horseshoe Lagoon.*

## THE SITE

The actual site of the 1966 nest was in a locality called Horseshoe Lagoon. The lagoon is approximately 40 feet wide and about 90 feet across in an approximately east-to-west direction. The locality gains its name from the horseshoe shape of the site. The water in the lagoon at the time of the incident was approximately six feet deep, but was largely obscured by dense swamp (sword grass) reed growth. These reeds were about half an inch thick and extended about two feet above the lagoon surface. The floor of the lagoon was a clay-base soil. In terms of access and view, Horseshoe Lagoon is open on its eastern side—the base of the U shape. This shape wraps around an area of trees and scrub. The lagoon is surrounded in all directions for some six kilometers by flat, lowland country. Some heavily forested areas are located some two kilometers to the south-southeast and to the south. Further isolated patches of trees are found among the sugar cane fields that dominate the area.

The lagoon is situated on property owned by Albert Pennisi. The Pennisi family has lived there since 1947. His residence is approximately 1.6 kilometers to the north. A line of trees about a kilometer north of the lagoon obstructs the view from the house.

## THE ENCOUNTER

At about 9:00 a.m. on January 19, 1966, George Pedley was driving a tractor heading south along a narrow track on Albert Pennisi's sugar cane farm.

The weather that morning was calm, with the sun shining at approximately 30 to 40 degrees east. When he was approximately 25 yards from Horseshoe Lagoon, Pedley

heard above the noise of the tractor, a loud hissing sound, "like air escaping from a tire."

"The tractor tires seemed O.K. to me, so I drove on," Pedley said. "Suddenly, an object rose out of the swamp. When I glanced at it, it was already 30 feet above the ground, and at about treetop level. It was a large, gray, saucer-shaped object, convex on the top and bottom and measured some 25 feet across and nine feet high. While I watched, it rose another 30 feet, spinning very fast, then it made a shallow dive and took off with tremendous speed.

"Climbing at an angle of 45 degrees it disappeared within seconds in a southwesterly direction. . . ." He added, "I saw no portholes or antennas, and there was no sign of life either in or about the ship."

## A PHYSICAL TRACE

When Pedley drove around the bend of the track to the lagoon, there, at the spot beneath where the object had risen, was a huge, round cleared area in the swamp grass. The water in this circular area was slowly rotating and appeared to be completely cleared of reeds. With this evidence of what he had observed, Pedley concluded, "I have really seen something!" He had passed the same spot some three hours earlier, as close as 12 feet, and had not seen anything unusual.

Within a few minutes, he returned to his tractor, which he found he had to restart. He had noted just immediately prior to hearing the hissing sound a noise like a misfire in the tractor motor. He was sure it had not stopped. As with most farmers it was not his habit to switch off the tractor motor until finished with it.

Later in the day, apparently about noon, George returned along the track and stopped for another inspection. The cleared area of the lagoon surface was no longer visible. What was clearly evident was a floating mass of reeds, approximately 30 feet in diameter, that had apparently come to the surface of the lagoon during the time Pedley was absent. The floating mass of reeds and grass was noticeably distributed in a radial pattern, in a clear clockwise manner. Pedley was certain the reeds were quite green in this mass, as they were in all the surrounding reeds in the lagoon.

Unable to keep this experience to himself, by about midafternoon George Pedley had told a friend, and also Albert Pennisi, the property owner. He led them both to the spot where the extraordinary evidence lay. Both were astounded. Neither had ever seen anything like this before, despite being experienced bushmen. Pennisi knew the area of his lagoon well, and a circular effect like this was totally unprecedented in his experience. Pennisi and Pedley waded out to the floating mass and found that it was possible to swim from either side under the mass. The water was clear of any obstructions and the lagoon floor beneath it was smooth and clear of any roots.

Pedley and Pennisi were most struck by a particular

feature of the surface of the floating reed bed—what seemed to be a clear print or impression of the UFO. The outer perimeter of the floating mass was thrust down markedly as if indented by a massive inverted saucer shape, with a circular center about six to eight feet in diameter. Pennisi rushed to his house and returned with a camera to take a series of photos. By then the upper surfaces of the reeds on top of the nest had turned brown. The underside of the reeds remained green. This browning had occurred by late afternoon, some eight hours after the sighting by Pedley.

## OTHER TRACE ANOMALIES

About six feet to the north of the nest, a rectangular patch of the swamp couch grass, approximately five by six feet, had been clipped at water level and pulled out completely. Pedley apparently noticed this initially with his original observation of the circular area. A further interesting anomaly was found by Christine Rounland, whose husband helped Pedley with crop fertilizing. She came across some ground markings that resembled curious tracks in looseplowed soil of an adjoining paddock between Pedley's banana palms. They led from the direction of the lagoon area and extended a short distance into the plowed field. They were shaped like a teardrop, pointed on one end and rounded at the other. Each was about three to four inches in length and about two inches across at their widest point. They were spaced out at about 12-inch intervals and in a straight line.

Subsequent underwater checks indicated three large holes in the muddy floor of the lagoon beneath the Pedley nest. Whether these were there at the time of the sighting could not be absolutely proven, but to some they suggested the possibility of tripod landing indentations.

Pedley also reported later that he noticed the presence of a "sulfur" smell in the area around the nest, just after the UFO had departed.

## THE NEST MILIEU DEVELOPS

While only the nest associated with George Pedley's sighting had an explicit connection with a UFO close encounter, other nests were found in quick succession in Horseshoe Lagoon. Though intriguing, none of the subsequent finds were as compelling as the original nest. The area became the focus of ongoing nest phenomena, and indeed Tully became known as the UFO capital of Australia. Tully had long been known as the locality with one of the highest regular rainfalls in Australia. The period of Pedley's encounter fell within the wet season, namely January to February. Usually this takes the form of heavy to drizzling rain. Hence it is easy to see why a weather phenomenon was deemed a possible explanation.

However, the facts do not lend themselves to this convenient answer. Strong winds during this wet season usually occur when cyclones are present. Pedley's encounter occurred during calm, fine weather. The prevailing

weather for the area in the 24 hours preceding the incident was not conducive to the formation of local windstorms. Locals are familiar with wind damage, even those involving small-scale vortices. These usually feature rougher and messy grass coverage disturbance and evidence of debris and trails in the immediate locality. None of this was evident.

When the news of George Pedley's encounter and the nest started to spread, coverage through the media proliferated. It was front page news. All sorts of theories abounded for the nest. Helicopters, nesting birds (Big Bird?), crocodiles, dogs, secret military devices, spaceships, reed-eating grubs, whirlwinds, and smaller vortex systems (known locally as "willy-willies") were among the many ideas trotted out. There was some confusion with regard to the direction of the nest spiral which persisted in various accounts over the years. The Pedley nest had a clockwise swirl. This aspect at least ruled out one explanation. The *Brisbane Courier Mail* on January 25, 1966, stated, "RAAF officials discounted the theory that 'nests' have been made by helicopters. The RAAF said that in depressions left by helicopters the grass usually ran in an anticlockwise direction—the main nest found at Tully ran in a clockwise direction."

Alf Macdonald, the stock-routes inspector for Northern Queensland, who had lived in the area since 1933, thought the wind-vortex theory was unlikely. He said that the district had not had a strong whirlwind, and indicated that they left a path anyway. George Pedley also commented, "I've seen wet whirlwinds and dust whirlwinds. If the police believe this, let them. I know what I saw. It wasn't a whirlwind." The Victorian Flying Saucer Research Society (now VUFORS) published an excellent item, "The Tully 'nests': How freakish can whirlwinds be?" which concluded that "the atmospheric vortex hypothesis" was untenable, despite cyclonic rotation in the southern hemisphere being clockwise. Large-scale vortex weather systems such as cyclones and whirlwinds largely have their rotation determined by the Coriolis effect, but local factors can negate these tendencies, particularly in willy willies.

Stan Seers of the Queensland Flying Saucer Research Bureau (QFSRB) arranged for samples to be taken by Albert Pennisi, namely reeds, mud, and water from the nest area and also from nearby grass. These were received in Brisbane on January 24 and submitted for examination to the Queensland University Botany and Physics departments. Results for radioactivity were minimal. All samples bar one were negative. The sample taken from the center of the nest showed a small increase in beta activity, much less than from a luminous wristwatch dial. Mr. G. Taylor, the staff physicist, confirmed that this was an insignificant result and was probably within background readings. Dr. Langdon of the botany department reported that the grass apparently died from submersion in swamp water. No evidence for parasitic infestation or burning was found. The submersion theory was not supported by the facts or local tests con-

ducted by Albert Pennisi at the suggestion of QFSRB. It seemed the reeds in the nest had turned brown in about eight hours. Reeds that were uprooted and submerged in swamp water turned brown after about three days.

Aerial and ground searches of the area were conducted in the wake of the Pedley find. Another two nests were found on January 20 by local farmer Tom Warren and school teacher Hank Penning, only 25 yards from the original nest. They were a few feet apart and only about a third of the diameter of the original. The reeds were flattened, one clockwise and the other counterclockwise. This find led to extensive searches. A week after the original find, cane farmer Lou Lardi and his nephew, Van Klaphake, discovered another two nests, both apparently much older than the Pedley find. One was about 12 feet in diameter and the other was eight feet, with distinct signs of burning in a circular patch of reeds in its center. A few days later, an identical "new" nest with an apparently scorched center was found among the earlier nests. The last three nests all had their reeds flattened in an counterclockwise fashion.

The traces found after the original nest, although interesting, are less compelling, because of the huge interest and presence of many people in the wake of the initial publicity. Although not proven, hoaxing may have been possible in the later finds. None of these nests had an apparent UFO connection.

There was extensive UFO activity being reported but none of it was related to explicit UFO landing events.

## THE FALLOUT

George Pedley, a bachelor, lived with Ashley Butler, 64, a neighboring farmer. He was known to be a quiet, hard worker. None of the locals had anything against him, even those who did not believe in his sighting. He said to journalists, "Had anyone asked me five days ago if I believed in flying saucers I'd have laughed and thought they were nuts. But now I know better."

Farmer George Pedley's sighting at Horseshoe Lagoon and the physical evidence found there caused a media sensation.

The *Brisbane Sunday Mail* for January 23 quoted Pedley:

I was driving the tractor through a neighbouring property on my way to my farm about 9 a.m. on Wednesday when I heard a loud hissing noise above the engine noise of the tractor.

At first I ignored the sound, but suddenly I saw a spaceship rise at great speed out of Horseshoe Lagoon, about 25 yards in front of me.

It was blue-grey, about 25 ft. across, and nine feet high. It spun at a terrific rate as it rose vertically to about 60 ft., then made a shallow dive and rose sharply. Travelling at a fantastic speed, it headed off in a south-westerly direction. I saw no portholes or antennae, and there was no sign of life either in or about the ship.

But on my way home to Tully that night I met Albert Pennisi, who owns the property where I saw the saucer. He said that about 5.30 a.m. on Wednesday his dog suddenly went mad and bounded off towards the lagoon.

## THE UFO MILIEU

While George Pedley was himself a skeptic converted by his experience, the January 19 sighting did not occur in a vacuum. One surprising element came out in an article by *Sun-Herald* journalist John Dickson on January 23. Pedley attributed the following to Albert Pennisi, the property owner:

He believed me straight away and told me he had been dreaming for a week that a flying saucer would land on his property.

He said that about 5.50 am on Wednesday [the morning of the discovery of the original nest] his dog suddenly went mad and bounded off towards the lagoon.

Pennisi elaborated on these dreams in an interview with the *Sydney Sun* on January 24, 1966. He was quoted by journalist Ben Davie:

I'd get them almost every night. And they were beginning to worry me. I couldn't understand them. It was always the same. This thing like a giant dish would come out of nowhere and land nearby. And I would watch it in my dream and get real afraid before it went away. Then on Wednesday morning about 5 o'clock my dog suddenly seemed to go out of its mind. It was howling like a mad thing and raced off towards the lagoon.

While Pennisi did not clarify this strange element to the Tully UFO saga, there were suggestions of paranormal happenings. Much of this information was anecdotal and unconfirmed.

More than a decade later, according to information I received, at nearby Murray Upper, a similar situation apparently unfolded. A young woman was awakened by her father apparently because he thought the house was on fire. There was a huge orange glow outside. They tried to wake up other family members without success. Fear started to overcome them and they ran down the hallway of the house away from the light. Their next recollection was that they both woke up the next morning extremely puzzled by what seemed to be a bizarre, shared dream. Over breakfast they heard radio reports of UFO sightings. They then realized their memories were not dreams. A circular area of flattened sugar cane was found near the house. I subsequently spoke with the young woman. While she only confirmed these events in a vague sort of way she did have a history that many would consider to be a classic UFO abduction. I even spoke to her father but he did not confirm the experience and was not keen to elaborate further. I was not able to confirm the validity of the affair.

There were other accounts in the surrounding area that

were somewhat suggestive but ultimately unconfirmable. For example, Ted Phillips's *Physical Traces Associated with UFO Sightings* catalogue (CUFOS, 1975) describes the following intriguing event:

At about 10 pm, on November 5th, 1971, in the South Johnstone area, two locomotive men of the South Johnstone Cooperative Sugar Milling Assoc., Ltd. were in the Number Two Branch area when the traffic control officer tried to contact them by radio. Jumbled and incoherent voices were heard. Believing an accident had occurred, a rescue party was sent out. One of the group observed a dazzling and powerful light in the area where burnt cane scarred by great heat was found. When they reached the driver and fireman they found them stupefied with one man repeatedly pointing to the sky. Both were taken to a hospital.

The source is cited as the *Evening Advocate*.

The UFO Investigation Centre (UFOIC) files of the early 1970s reveal a possible partial confirmation of the story. A correspondent referred to what was apparently this incident:

It was either during the inward or the outward trip of a loco that the driver and his mate saw a strange light in one of the fields. On investigation of the light, the men are reported to have seen some kind of strange object in the field . . . The upshot was that they were placed in hospital under sedation, for about 2 weeks, due probably to hysteria. . . .

One of the most prolific sources of UFO stories from the Tully area was local witness Claire Noble. She reported on extensive activity that preceded the famous Pedley sighting of January 1966. According to Noble there had been aboriginal stories spanning many years from Tully Gorge, the Murray River, and mountain areas around Tully.

Apparently aboriginal folklore suggested similar occurrences from earlier times although I have not come across explicit evidence of this. One of the earlier reports came from near Euramo, the closest village to Horseshoe Lagoon. In September 1959, a Max Menzel was driving a tractor when he spotted "a brilliant, large, conical craft, approximately 30 feet long," which seemed to be hovering over the top of a stand of sugar cane, just 100 feet away. A nearby house was illuminated in a vivid red and orange light. There was a proliferation of sightings through 1965, including an apparent nighttime landing on the slopes of Mount Mackay on November 29.

Activity surged for months in the wake of Pedley's experience. The Tully district seemed to be haunted by UFOs. Nest activity reoccurred during early 1968, culminating in a strange affair involving a remote UFO detector and linked camera at Horseshoe Lagoon being triggered and running off footage. The undeveloped footage was posted off to Kodak. The package was returned with a note from Kodak saying the container contained no film on

arrival in Melbourne, despite the original postage being indicative of a film being present. Investigators even used a local member of parliament to try to get to the bottom of the missing film mystery, but all to no avail.

Nest activity also occurred at Horseshoe Lagoon during subsequent years including 1969, 1972, 1975, 1981, and 1987. By 1990 Albert Pennisi was indicating there had been 22 nests at his lagoon since 1966. However, none were as compelling with regard to an explicit UFO connection as George Pedley's find in 1966. While hoaxing and misinterpretation was suggested in some of the later finds, such allegations were not applicable to the original nest.

## PEDLEY SPEAKS

I have spoken to George Pedley on a number of occasions. Initially I found him to be reluctant to resurrect his experience. However, he was interested enough to assist a serious attempt to clarify what had happened. On June 13, 1981, I interviewed him:

B.C.: From what I have read, you saw what you called a spaceship? You didn't really describe it in much detail.

G.P.: Oh, I would never have said I saw a spaceship!

B.C.: That's what the papers were quoting you as saying.

G.P.: Well, that's wrong for a start. I saw an object . . . something going up and that's it. Just what it was, I don't know.

B.C.: What did you really see?

G.P.: Well, I just saw this thing in the sky and it took off! It was about 25 feet when I saw it. 25 to 30 feet in the air, when I saw it.

B.C.: It was in the air when you saw it?

G.P.: Oh yes, I didn't see it in the lagoon as they say. That's wrong. The marks were in the lagoon . . . and it just took off from there (in the air). It went up another 25 feet and it just flew straight out.

B.C.: So you saw it rise up from a position of about 20 feet when you first saw it.

G.P.: That's right.

B.C.: And the position where you first saw it, was that in the same spot where the nests were found?

G.P.: You mean the object?

B.C.: Yes, where you saw the object rise up, you say you saw it originally from 20 feet in the air, roughly about 20 feet in the air . . .

G.P.: Yeah . . .

B.C.: Where the nests were subsequently found, was that directly beneath that position or . . .

G.P.: That's correct.

B.C.: What sort of size would you have put on it?

G.P.: Size? Oh, the size was pretty right. I'd say 29–30 feet,

something like that.

B.C.: Did you get the impression of an object, or was it sort of a solid-looking thing or gaseous . . .

G.P.: Well, I thought it was a solid thing, at the time. I didn't see any portholes, or anything like that, antennas or anything like that. They could have been there, I'm not saying they weren't there.

B.C.: What sort of shape would you have put on it?

G.P.: Something similar to like two saucers, you know, face to face . . .

B.C.: What sort of color?

G.P.: It seemed a silvery gray, a blue gray, like that.

G.P.: [With regard to the media assertions that he saw the object rise up out of the lagoon] I think there was a little bit of misunderstanding there. I would say it was their fault. Anyway, I'd never say that.

B.C.: So how long in sight was it for?

G.P.: We worked it out to say 30 seconds.

## THE RAAF FILES

The Royal Australian Air Force (RAAF) files describe the famous Tully incident in the following manner:

At about 9.00 a.m. on 19th January, 1966, Mr. G. A. Pedley, a banana grower of Tully, Qld, observed a light grey non reflecting dull object, reported to be about 25 feet long and 8 feet deep, rise vertically then climb on an angle of 45° from a height of about 30 feet above marshland which was situated about 25 yards away from his position. There was an associated hissing noise which decreased as the "object" rose. The apparent shape was described as "two saucers, face to face," but no structural detail was observed. The duration of the observation was approximately 15 seconds and it disappeared in mid-air whilst receding into the distance (not assessed).

A clearly defined near circular depression remained in evidence in swamp grass at the point from which the object was seen rising, and measured about 32 feet long by 25 feet wide. The grass was flattened in clockwise curves to water level within the circle and the reeds had been uprooted from the mud. There was no scorching of grass or surrounding trees and the observer stated that there was no smell of combustion . . .

My research of the RAAF files uncovered the original police report on the incident. As these are the earliest documented sources, extracts of it are included here of details not included in the above statement made in 1973 in response to an enquiry from the Australian newspaper.

George Pedley reported his experience to Tully Police at 7.30 p.m. on January 19. At 7:00 a.m. on January 20, George Pedley and Sgt. A. V. Moylan went to the site of the

incident. Sgt. Moylan then contacted Townsville RAAF Base by telephone on the morning of January 20. Flt. Lt. Wallace advised Moylan that he would forward a pro forma questionnaire for completion by Pedley.

On Friday, January 21st, Wallace confirmed dispatch of two copies of the sighting pro forma by mail that same day and also requested Moylan obtain "a sample of the grass from the scorched area." At 3:30 p.m. on the same day, Moylan returned to the site and took a sample "of the grass from the depression in the swamp grass at the site."

The pro forma was filled out by Moylan based on his interviews with Pedley and was dated January 26. Moylan dispatched the report and the sample on the same day.

The following details are extracted from the "RAAF Report on Aerial Object Observed" that Moylan filled out with George Pedley. Because so many conflicting claims have been made about what Pedley said at the time, it is worthwhile to go back to the original official documentation filled out at the time of the incident:

Name of Observer: George Alfred PEDLEY aged 28 years.

Manner of observation: travelling on a tractor about ½ mile from farm house of Albert PENNISI, Rockingham Road, Euramo. Attention attracted by hissing noise, clearly heard over noise of tractor—similar to air escaping from tyre; checked tyres and was looking about for source of noise when he saw object about 25 yards ahead. No optical instruments used in sighting.

Height or angle of elevation: First seen at treetop height 30¢ Rose vertically to about twice that height, then departed, climbing at about 45 degrees.

Speed, or angular velocity: Extremely fast; No estimate of speed, but much faster than an aeroplane. It was near treetops and these gave observer a good basis for estimating height.

Direction of flight with reference to landmarks or points of the compass: Rose vertically to about 60 feet and departed south west climbing at about 45 degrees; appeared to be rotating for full time observed. (object appeared to remain on) straight climbing path.

Existence of any physical evidence: Clearly defined near-circular depression in swamp grass at point from which object seen rising, about 32¢long and 25¢wide. Grass flattened to surface of 4' of water lying in anti-clockwise curves.

Sgt. Moylan in his report had typed in anticlockwise initially and then corrected it to clockwise, by overtyping "anti" with "xxxx." The direction of the swirl at the site of the 19 January 1966 incident was to become a matter of ongoing confusion. The clockwise direction was the correct direction.

Weather conditions experienced at time of observation: Clear sky; Hot sunshine.

Location of any air traffic in the vicinity at the time of sighting: Unknown but checked by RAAF Garbutt.

Flt. Lt. Wallace of Townsville RAAF base, in a covering minute paper, confirmed that "there were no service or Civil aircraft operating in the area . . . at the time of the sighting."

Any additional information: [Moylan wrote] Observer reported this matter to Tully Police at 7.30pm on 19/1/66 and at 7am, 20/1/66 went with me to the site of the depression in the swamp. His version then included the information that the object rose vertically, appeared to dip slightly and then went off in straight climbing path. He then said . . . further that there was no smell of combustion and no scorching of grass or trees visible; that the flattened grass or rushes was quite green when he first saw the depression; on his return that afternoon the grass had turned brown.

[Moylan further added:] In this matter I formed the opinion that the depressed area in the swamp grass had been caused by a small helicopter and that the observer, in the early morning bright sunlight shining on the rotor may have mistaken the shape. His description of the take off lent some strength to my opinion.

However there was cleared land to the east for about 200 yards where such an aircraft could have more safely landed instead of the position indicated by the observer, close to trees. Later I was informed by Wallace Evans of . . . Tully, an electrician, that he has seen similar markings in a swamp at Kurrumine Beach and is quite certain that it was caused by a whirlwind, sucking up water into a waterspout, uprooting the grass and laying it out in a similar pattern. At 3.30pm, 21/1/66 I took a sample of the grass at the site and have forwarded it under separate cover on even date.

Flt. Lt. T. D. Wright, for Air Officer Commanding, Headquarters Operational Command, RAAF, Penrith, New South Wales, forwarded Moylan's report on Pedley's UFO sighting and Wallace's covering minute paper, to the Department of Air, Russell Offices, Canberra. His communication, classified "restricted" and channelled to the Directorate of Air Force Intelligence (DAFI), also indicated, "This headquarters believes that the depressions of the swamp grass were caused by small isolated waterspouts."

In response to an inquiry, dated February 2, 1966, from the Commonwealth Aerial Phenomena Investigation Organisation (CAPIO), the Secretary of the Department of Air, A. B. McFarlane, wrote on February 11:

Investigations of the area surrounding the reported "Nests," testing of samples taken from around them and interrogation of persons involved in the report failed to reveal anything of significance.

However, during enquiries a number of local residents stated that the reported "nests" are fairly common during the onset of the "wet."

Furthermore, the University of Queensland stated that there was nothing unnatural in the samples submitted and assessed that the "nests" could have been the result of

severe turbulence, which normally accompany line squalls and thunderstorms prevalent in NORTH QUEENSLAND at the time of the year.

There is no explanation for the visible phenomena reported but it could have been associated with or the result of "down draughts," "willy willies" or "water spouts" that are known to occur in the area.

... for information ... in January of this year from an airfield in the tropics [a number of photographs taken give] a fine example of the type and growth of a cloud formation occurring with a severe "down draught." This whirling mass of tropical air associated with thunderstorm activity, on reaching the earth's surface may dissipate and subside or persist giving rise to dust eddies, water spouts, etc., leaving a telltale circular pattern on the ground. Should it occur over a swampy reed bed the effect would be to flatten the reeds with a circular pattern. Resultant photographs and investigations of the "nests" seem to fit in with this theory and is accepted as a possible cause of the phenomena.

It is fascinating to note how McFarlane's cursory explanatory exposition, no doubt inspired by "the tornado-like meteorological phenomena" that infested skies over Willow Grove, Victoria (Charles Brew's famous 1963 close encounter) and Vacluse Beach, New South Wales (Dennis Crowe's striking suburban encounter in 1965)—see Part Two of this article—anticipated by almost two decades Dr. Terence Meaden's early theoretical attempts to explain the English "crop circles" of the 1980s. Meaden would mistakenly assume that George Pedley saw his "vortex" at 9 p.m., not 9 a.m., which was a fatal flaw in the mechanism he originally put forth to explain the report.

*Editor's note: Bill Chalker's study of the Tully saucer-nest will conclude in the Spring 1998 issue, where the crop-circle phenomenon will be compared with the Australian nests.* ♦

## SHAG HARBOUR—continued from page 9

uncle, were two of the first fishing-boat owners contacted and each agreed immediately to go to their boats berthed at the Government Wharf at the center of the village. Two of the Mounties, Werbicki and O'Brien, split up, one each to a boat. Pond was left to continue his interviews with the witnesses.

Norm Smith went out with Shand while Wifred, his father, climbed aboard his brother Lawrence's boat. Within minutes they had cast off and were making to the west of the harbor, through the channel at Prospect Point and out onto the Sound.

In the lead, Lawrence Smith took a sighting on the Budget Light and began to run down on it. One mile out on the Sound they ran into the first evidence of the dark object they had watched from the shore, a three- or four-inch thick, glittery, yellow foam stretching down the Sound for a half

mile and about two boat-lengths or 80 feet wide. Bubbles roiled to the surface in places, and there was the smell of sulfur in the area.

Neither Smith nor Shand were fussy about sailing through the stuff, but expressed concerns about buoyancy. Their choices were limited. This was the area where the "airplane" went down and the most likely place for survivors. So with trepidation and a natural reluctance to finally come upon what all of them feared and believed was there, bodies and hopefully some survivors, they carried on their search.

Nearly an hour later, still nothing had been found and now Coast Guard Cutter 101 arrived on site from its berth at Cape Sable Island some 15 miles away. It was nearly 12:45 a.m. local time and hope was fading fast for finding any survivors. Werbicki was called to the cabin on Shand's boat. Shand handed him the microphone from the vessel's marine-band radio informing him that there was a message from Ronnie Newell, the skipper of the Coast Guard cutter.

Newell reported that he had just received a message from the Rescue Coordination Center, the military manned facility in Halifax. All aircraft, both commercial and military, were accounted for up and down the eastern seaboard of Atlantic Canada, and well down into New England. No private aircraft were reported missing.

Werbicki informed the others on his vessel and the word quickly spread through the now expanded flotilla of six small craft. No airplane had crashed here. That of course made the next question obvious to the searchers. If no airplane had crashed here, then what were they looking for?

The Air Desk in Ottawa, that sector of the Royal Canadian Air Force responsible for the gathering and investigation of UFO reports, tagged the sighting as the crash of a UFO and in other reports referred to it as a "dark object." The RCMP in their reports referred to the craft as a UFO. They had no choice, for all other explanations for the event did not fit the scenario.

Whatever crashed or landed in the waters near Shag Harbour, it was not a meteor, meteor train, space junk, or any earthly vehicle. Even errant Soviet or American missile shots have been ruled out, as has the possibility of it being a dropped H-bomb as happened in the waters off Spain.

One thing is for certain. This event was probably the best documented case of a UFO crash in the history of UFO crashes and somehow got missed by researchers over the years; this despite the fact that as Case #34 it was classed as one of the few unsolved cases in the infamous Condon Report. Like Roswell, this case sank into oblivion, not to resurface until Chris Styles, later joined by myself, rediscovered it 26 years later. Now 30 years later and four years into the investigation, the evidence has grown to the point that we are certain that what happened at Shag Harbour was only the tip of the iceberg and the beginning of a seven-day adventure involving two objects, the navy and air forces of two countries, and NORAD.

But that is another story. ♦

---

# MY MISSION FROM THE ASHTAR COMMAND

BY BRUCE MACCABEE

**I**n early January 1997 a thought suddenly came to me. The 50th anniversary of the Arnold sighting was fast approaching, and so far as I knew, no one had composed a musical piece in honor of the occasion. So why not I? I had already been asked by Bill Murphy, who was in charge of the 1997 MUFON symposium, to play 1940s popular music on the piano during the reception Friday night (July 11), so I knew there would be an opportunity, a venue, for the performance of such a piece. What I didn't know was whether or not I could actually create a worthwhile piece by that time. I have composed a number of keyboard pieces, many of which have been recorded, but never with a requirement to meet a deadline.

## NEW AGE RISING

But then the ideas started to come. Not into my conscious understanding, as with Mozart or the classical geniuses who could "hear" or "see" much of the composition before they started writing it. I can't hear the music first. No, these ideas come directly from my fingers. I composed, you might say, by automatic playing. These short sections—"riffs" in musical jargon—just leap out of my fingers, from somewhere. It is my job to sort through the riffs and pick the interesting ones and arrange them in logical order.

Little by little over the following months the various sections of the piece came to me. Not only that, but I knew where to place them in the piece to create a composition in which the various sections are related to UFO issues and to the fact that UFO sightings are changing our understanding of ourselves and the universe.

By late May I knew I had done it. I had created a decodable composition which, when properly interpreted, represents the questions surrounding the appearance of flying saucers and aliens, the controversy over sightings, and the efforts of skeptics to explain and debunk sightings. All of this is set against the framework of a theme that begins in the lowest frequencies of the keyboard and rises

gradually, suffering several setbacks, into the upper registers where it eventually triumphs at the end, leaving only the question of what all this means. The rising theme represents the onset of a new age. I named the piece "New Age Rising." The title notwithstanding, it is *not* "New Age music."

## BROTHER IN THE DARKNESS

After I performed this composition at the MUFON reception, a lady asked me if I thought I had received any "outside help." She made it clear that she thought I might have received help from the guys upstairs. I didn't think so, but then I began to wonder: where do these musical ideas come from anyway? From within my own psyche? From the random musical meanderings of my own mind? Or could they have come from somewhere else? Were my thoughts controlled from the outside? I doubt it, but let me tell you a story.

In the fall of 1988, I got a message directly from the Ashtar Command. It came through a woman whom I'll call Joan Jones (no resemblance to her real name).

From the Ashtar Command? What sort of joke is this? That was my reaction. I was surprised, perhaps even shocked. I don't pay too much attention to channeled material. I have read treatises by persons who claim to get information from Space Brothers (and Sisters; evidently they have sex in space). I find these writings confusing and disappointing. There are lots of phrases and jargon that don't seem to mean anything beyond grade-school moralizing and philosophy interspersed with pseudotechnical descriptions of how space flight is accomplished. (I wish one channel would provide a complete description of how to modify or add to Maxwell's electrodynamic equations or Einstein's gravitational theory in order to derive predictive results that would confirm the transmission of information or matter faster than the speed of light.) Phrases such as the "fourth density" or "fourth racers" or "higher dimensions" or "colors and higher vibrations" or "starships" and "galactic command" roll off my brain like water off a rock's back.

In other words, the woman's announcement did not impress me.

---

*Bruce Maccabee, Ph.D., is the coauthor of UFOs Are Real ... Here's the Proof (1997) and a regular contributor to IUR.*

However, the intriguing fact was that Joan was and is not a channel. She is a well-off, middle-aged housewife and practitioner and teacher of yoga and meditation. She told me that usually after she meditates, achieving some sort of trance state, she writes in a little notebook a summary of her thoughts. She said that though she had a few times in previous years received what seemed to her to be "voices" or messages, she was not a devotee of channeling and did not intend to become one. She took the time to tell me about this, she said, only because the "message" was specifically directed to me and she hesitated to ignore it altogether. Anyway, she wanted to give me the option of doing whatever I wanted with it.

I should point out that she was no more interested in UFOs than the average person, seeing occasional movies, television shows, and so on, but not going out of the way to acquire UFO information. Though she was aware of my UFO interests, we have never really discussed the subject before the one time she visited my house for an hour or so, in May 1988, to see photos taken by Ed Walters in Gulf Breeze, Florida. We had no communication (at least none I recall) after that until about four months later when she informed me of the message.

She gave me a xerox copy of the pages from her journal. Her journal is a book with little sayings across the top of each page; the rest is just blank paper. For example, at the top of the first of the pages she sent me is written, "We always hope; and in all things it is better to hope than to despair. When we return to real trust in God, there will no longer be room in our soul for fear (Goethe)."

What follows is a transcription of her handwriting. Words in brackets are my editorial insertions. At the top of the first page she sent me she has written her feelings about her life. These writings have nothing to do with the present subject, but I have included them anyway to provide an example of the type of material she normally puts into her little book. Here, then, are the writings of "Joan Jones, Yoga Practitioner," on a day in September 1988:

[I wanted to] get this book so I can continue recording my Sadhana. God is certainly with me this morning. I made some vows this week to stay regular with my Sadhana. Maybe I'll even start up my spiritual diary sheets again.... It's been almost ten years since I did that! Home feels good and I am excited and elated. So many new beginnings, things to do, people to connect with. Oh how sweet it was to connect with [name removed] and now I will stop and do my exercises.

[Here a line across the page indicates the next day.]

After meditations this a.m. I had a channeling from Ashtar command and Mary, my dearly departed yogi friend [Mary had died a year earlier]. First he talked, telling me of his mission and to tell Bruce Maccabee to stay out of his way, not to try to stop him. He wants all the godless souls. The lost souls who do not meditate or pray will go aboard his spaceships all over the world when he is ready for them to come and colonize his star-

planets. They will think they are escaping death through the destruction of earth planet. I and my family of yogis will not be taken as we are to stay and console and heal this planet. Also because we cannot be bent to his command as the others can. Then Mary spoke:

"I am here, wedded to Ashtar, his queen. We communicate through mind and it was God's will for me to be with him. I can keep him from hurting earthlings. Without me here to calm him he is ruthless and uncaring. I am his conscience. It is my duty to do this. It is better than earth, because I cared nothing for sex, body, and material desires. There's none of that here. I have produced many earth starlings. When you come to God someday I will see you then. But please contact 'Mr./Dr.' Maccabee. If he cooperates with us rather than fight us, he can have whatever he wants. Otherwise we will ruin him. Let him know that. We will not contact you again unless he has further messages for us. Otherwise, that's all."

Reading this, I was of several minds. One mind said, "What the hell is that?" Another mind answered, "This is all crap." Yet a third, more analytical mind said, "What if this really means something? How have I been hindering or obstructing the plans of Ashtar? I should think that proving UFOs are real would help Ashtar. Who is he to threaten me with ruination if I don't cooperate?"

Of course I had heard of Ashtar. Everybody has heard of Ashtar. Right? Wrong, maybe. I asked Joan. She didn't know who Ashtar was, or at least she didn't recall hearing or reading the name before the message came. On the other hand, the name has been associated with flying saucers for a long time, beginning with the 1952 channelings of California contactee George Van Tassel. One of the many extraterrestrials who sent him psychic communications called himself Ashtar. Other contactees channeled Ashtar after that, and he became something of a metaphysical superstar.

Obviously, Joan could have heard or read the name Ashtar somewhere in previous years, so it could have been buried deeply in her psyche. But this wouldn't explain the message with its ominous, foreboding overtones and its nasty warning to me.

When Joan gave me the copy of her notebook pages, she stressed again that she did not want to be a channel for outer-space creatures or for any such entity. However (here's that "however" again), in this case, since the message had ended almost with an invitation for me to contact the Ashtar Command, she said she would be willing to establish a contact during a future meditation if I had anything to ask or say to Ashtar.

I didn't really believe this was a message from an extraordinary source. At the same time I felt something like a person offered one wish from a genie. I could have anything I wanted, but it had better be the right thing the first time. I didn't know what it meant to cooperate with Ashtar; yet if I failed to cooperate, I would be "ruined."

Mulling it over, I decided I would ask a question: "What constitutes cooperation?" If I were told to stop doing something that I wasn't doing, I would know this message was solely the product of Joan's imagination. On the other hand, it might be interesting if the response did provide details on how to cooperate. In either case I figured this would smoke out any jokers in the deck.

Many years earlier I had gone to a lecture by Valerie Ranson, who in the late 1970s was trying to raise money for a project to usher in a New Age of Space Brothers and other good things. A trance channel, she demonstrated her talents during the lecture. I got to ask her a question during the channeling. I asked whether or not life in the universe had been seeded by "panspermia" (the scientific theory that the progenitors of life are carried by comets and meteors and that when these land on habitable planets, life begins). She mumbled and sputtered a bit, then complained that I shouldn't ask such incomprehensible questions. She went quickly to the next question from somebody else. As far as I was concerned, she had flunked the channel test.

This was different, however. Here was someone I had known for a few years, a presumably levelheaded member of the community, saying impossible things which were totally out of character for her. I had to treat this with more respect. I had to allow for the possibility that the Ashtar message might have some germ of truth.

Consequently, I figured that this question, what constitutes cooperation, would test the channel while at the same time providing some useful information if, in fact, the previous message came from a real entity. If Ashtar wanted me to cooperate rather than hinder him, he could simply explain what he wanted me to do. I assumed Ashtar, if a real entity, could have known of my UFO activities (investigation, analysis, writing); if any one of these was hindering his mission, he could tell me so. Then I would know what to do to get on his good side.

## PLAYING INTO THEIR HANDS

I didn't think of it as a hostile question, but apparently Ashtar did. You can imagine my surprise when I got the following message a few weeks later. Ashtar is responding (in italics) to questions and comments (in quotation marks) posed by Joan:

"What constitutes cooperation?"

*What a silly question. What impudence! Know that we are in control of the situation. You are playing right into our hands.*

"Is what you are doing for our good?"

*What is good? We are doing what is necessary. We have been with you for a long time. We are there with you without physical form. Yes, even now our presence are [sic] in this room and we are guiding your actions. There are ways through thought control to have you perform [act according to] our wishes. You certainly must know how*

*compelled you are with this project. That is our bidding. Your own purity is the only thing that blocks our communication. But who is pure in your society? Very few, so our work is easy to execute. As writers, scientists, channelers, teachers, and especially the confused ones, who are easiest to manipulate, you are serving our purpose and we will have our way. There is no way you will stop us now.*

*"Oh, my, what harshness and lack of feeling and care." We have no emotions, only humans do.*

Well. So I'm called impudent simply for asking a question. It was as if Ashtar were saying brusquely, "How dare you ask that question when you know the answer already?" In other words, I should have known what "cooperation" amounted to.

The message was even weirder than the first one in the following way: In the first message Ashtar gave the impression that I was hindering his activities. He did not explain what I was doing in that regard, but at least he was clear that I was doing something bad. He also informed me that nothing I or anyone could do would stop him. So why was he worried about puny little me?

## AN UNKNOWING MISSIONARY

This message upset Joan. After all, these were her spirit guides, so she thought, and she didn't like their cold, unfeeling attitude. So she tried one more time to make contact. Here is the result:

*We are not your guides. No, they are not we.*

*"Why are you contacting me?"*

*Because we want you to know.*

*"What do you want?"*

*We will do what we need to do for our purposes. Actually your connection to us is through Mary who always has tried to reach you through us.*

*"Mary?"*

[At this point Mary starts communicating.]

*"Joan, I live here by my desire to take a physical form when I want to, although we do not need it at all for our work. It is God's will that I be here where I can help. I can't say more."*

[Here Joan inserts a statement of something she has just realized.]

*"One of them wants me ashe [emphasis in original] has Mary!!!"*

[She asks another question.]

*"And what about Bruce?"*

*We have no souls and no actual brains[,] only the nonphysical mind. We can use Bruce's brain to do our mind work and your soul to do our body work in the plane in which you both live. We have allowed you both [to] live. We have allowed and encouraged Bruce to do his work since before his first wife and he split—we caused that through his work. Christine [my second wife] is an aide to him as well*

*as your connection to us through each other. [Christine introduced me to Joan.] She binds him to our cause through their children which was our design and to you through your friendship with Christine. It is a web of intrigue which we wove.*

*"Why?"*

*As we have stated for our purposes, which will be known to the world in due time, and your place in it. You will both continue to be our missionaries on earth to the end of your lives and we don't interfere with you because we don't need to. You are both very stable, reliable, [and] dependable and are not trying to escape our designs. Even your guru, Swami [name withheld], plays a part in this. We contact him in his meditations regularly and he knows of us. Because he is higher evolved than you and can lead others to us. He is an honorable man but led by his destiny to purify you for us and others like you.*

*"What?"*

*Just stop now and go do your work.*

This message was not so harsh as the previous ones, but it does indicate that I am (as is Joan) like a puppet in a cosmic drama orchestrated by the puppet masters. We were each acting our parts, with the earth as our stage, carrying out a prescribed plan contained within a cosmic script for the universe, a "web of intrigue" woven by powers I can barely contemplate. Perhaps the Greeks were correct to attribute the vagaries of life to the actions of something like the Fates sitting on high, spinning, and then cutting the thread of life.

Of course no one, or at least no mere human, can explain everything that happens in life, and I certainly wouldn't attempt it for my life. But Ashtar's explanation for the failure of my first marriage, failure because of my "work," is wrong.

Moreover, Ashtar's claim that I am one of his missionaries seems just as incorrect. I had never promoted Ashtar and, if anything, had pooh-poohed him and other channeled entities. On the other hand, I suppose that one could argue that this article fulfills that prophecy. Perhaps merely by writing it, I am playing into Ashtar's hands and acting as his missionary.

## **BROTHER IN THE LIGHT**

In the middle of November, Joan gave me the last message. I knew there was nothing I could do in response to it or the others. If they were real in some sense, then Ashtar, I presumed, had everything under control irrespective of what I did. If they were not real—which was my view—they were merely an amusement to be laughed about and forgotten. Joan did not care to do further channeling with such unfeeling beings, and I really didn't want her to pursue the matter. What was the point? The material seemed as unintelligible and inconsistent as other channeled material I had read.

Furthermore, I found it embarrassing to think that I, a physical scientist who believes only in the "channel" of electromagnetic radiation (or other physical "channels") for information transmission, would be confronted with this sort of information channeled by a reasonably credible person from an incredible source. I told no one (only I, Joan, and Christine knew). Thinking it might be the basis for a lighthearted article sometime in the future, I filed it away. I would have forgotten about it if it hadn't been for Norma Milanovich and Bob Oechsler.

Bob had heard about Norma and her "automatic typing" of messages from the Space Brothers. He mentioned it to me one day in December 1988, barely a month after the last communication from Ashtar. He wanted to try an experiment to test the accuracy of channeled information. At first I resisted, but then it occurred to me that maybe an experiment might be worth doing, after all. Suppose, I thought, we ask Mrs. Milanovich to contact the Ashtar Command and found out if she got the same messages I had just received through Joan.

I showed the Ashtar messages to Bob, and he agreed it would be an interesting test. Two main things stood out: the messages were critical of me, and they had no apparent exhortation to humanity (ban the bomb, clean up pollution, love your mother, or whatever). The first message also had cryptic references to earth's destruction and the transportation of humans to other planets. We both knew that channeled messages traditionally have platitudinous messages to individuals and portentous states of warning to humanity in general. Therefore, if Norma came up with the same sorts of nasty messages I got from Joan, she would be going against the tradition of benign channeled information.

I did not contact Norma. Bob did, with a simple question for the Arcturians (the entities she channeled): "Has Dr. Maccabee been sent a message from Ashtar (through a medium) recently, and if so, could you repeat the message?" Bob carefully avoided giving any hint of the content of the messages I had received. This question clearly put the burden on the channel to come up with the correct message.

In February 1989 contact was established. Norma produced five single-spaced pages of channeled material. I will quote some and paraphrase some in the same order she typed it:

Good evening Daughter in the Light. I AM [capitals in original] Juluionno, the Commander of the Starship, who will address your question this evening. I come out of respect for the Highest of the Masters and Tribunal Council asking that you allow me to make the formal introduction between your soon-to-be friend, Dr. Maccabee, and our Beloved Celestial Commander of the ethers.

At this point Juluionno described himself as in "the position of the lowest in the stations when it comes to the repeating of the message that was meant to be delivered to the Earth-

based scientist." Remarking on the previous messages (from Joan), he says:

It was not the information he was intended to have. The only being who can deliver the true words of wisdom that our Brother needs to hear is the Supreme Commander who wishes for him to have a true message intended for his essence.

In other words, according to Juluionno, my "essence" got the wrong message before. Now I would get the "true message" right from the Commander's mouth or mouth-piece. I guess a cynic could say this was a clever way of negating the accuracy of any previous message, whatever it might have been. Of course, my previous message was also supposedly from Ashtar. Was that the wrong Ashtar? Would Norma be channeling a different Ashtar? Would the real Ashtar please beam down?

Juluionno offered a few more introductory comments regarding the "energy sent with this signal transmission" which would "reach far and wide into the consciousness and the hearts of the select few of the Council," and then formally introduced "Beloved Ashtar." Ashtar began his message to me in a manner guaranteed to grab my attention:

Greetings Commander Maccabee, in the Light of Our Most Radiant One. I commute through this dedicated channel this evening to assure that the words that you have received are indeed incomplete and that more information is coming. I, Ashtar, do greet you with all of the respect that is deserving of your soul and rank, and do not hesitate to accept your hand in friendship, as is so often the case on the earth plane.

Now, this is more like it. I'm a Commander, no less. Perhaps I had been promoted since Joan's messages a couple of months earlier. It is interesting that Ashtar did not say the previous message was wrong, only that it was incomplete.

Ashtar went on to say that though weapons were probably my first interest (after all, I work for the Navy), they were the "least important item on the agenda that will be addressed in any of the conversation(s) that we may have, now or in the future." In fact, Ashtar said nothing about weapons. Instead, he discussed an "issue that is incomplete, and one which is so pressing." This is "the usage of the human energy systems and the problems that are resulting from the misuse of those systems." He observed, "As an earth scientist I know you can and will identify with this. As Being of the Light, I also know that you are concerned."

Nonetheless, Ashtar gently chided me for not being sufficiently concerned "to help the Beloved Terra take control of her own destiny." Realizing that some of what he said might be over my head, Ashtar in a sense apologized for using concepts I could not be expected to understand: "I anticipate that this comment [about Beloved Terra] will not make much sense . . . and [you] might register a note of disappointment. But allow me to continue and I hope that I

may be able to convince you that this is the utmost priority of the energy issues that affect the Earth today."

Ashtar discussed various energies which "earth scientists have not yet discovered," such as "the collective oneness of the Liquid Light" that can't be seen in microscopic investigations. According to Ashtar, the failure to identify these other energy sources derives from our tendency to "view the energies as separate sources of power [which] . . . can be measured with different technological instruments." He said, "The problem with this is that in the separateness comes the separation." (I think I'll put that over my desk.) Moreover: "In the separation comes the unification of the closed mindedness." (I'll put this one over my mirror.) And finally: "In the close mindedness comes the shutting off of the most important source of energy that this universe or its Beings have yet to encounter." And what is that source? "The frequency that vibrates faster than any other, and that which is the creator of all the other forms of matter that exist on Earth."

In earthly English here is what I think Ashtar meant:

Scientists are wrong to take a "microscopic" or reductionist approach to the understanding of the physical universe. In so doing, they miss the larger picture. It's like missing a forest's existence because you are spending all your time staring at individual trees. The opposite approach has been called "holistic," in which you are trying to study everything at once. Unfortunately, our minds are unable to comprehend everything at once; the best we can do is understand the details of a piece of the whole. This has led to fractionation or splitting of science into numerous sections and subsections of study. Following reduction and analysis, there is a synthesis or recombining to form a complete understanding of some area of research. This approach has proved successful in helping us to comprehend and use the physical, chemical, and biological laws of nature. For example, the computer system Norma was using when she typed the message was a product of a long chain of reductionist analysis (materials science, solid-state physics, electronics, mechanical engineering, mathematics, and more) followed by synthesis.

Ashtar said that scientific reductionism (viewing "the energies as separate sources of power") had caused everyone to overlook the most important source of energy, "that which vibrates faster than any other." Unfortunately for mankind, Ashtar did not specify just *what* vibrates "faster than any other"; nor did he say how to harness this vibration to provide "power." Knowing that something vibrates "faster than any other" does not translate into anything we can use as a source of energy. As a physicist I am struck by how little substance there is in these remarks.

It is interesting to note, however, that modern scientific theory views the vacuum—the space between globs of matter—as a highly energetic volume of space. Since energy is directly related to frequency of electromagnetic radiation, there is, perhaps, some justification for referring to the vacuum as "that which vibrates faster than any other."

Since 99% of everything is vacuum, there surely is a lot of vibration going on in the universe.

Ashtar then asked two questions related to the importance of vibration: "Since that frequency and energy are truly the essence of the Highest, it would only seem reasonable that all things created must be of that frequency. Does it not? And does it not seem right that all things are created out of and under that Highest form of life?" My answers to these questions are "perhaps" and "maybe," supplemented with "hmmm, damned if I know."

He turned to unchangeable rules of the universe and law enforcement on earth, which "is often accomplished ... in the manner that promotes fear and guilt," as compared to enforcement on "higher levels," here "accomplished out of love and respect for creation. . . . That difference is absolute and uncompromising, for the difference of the mode of operations between our two worlds at this time are [sic] too far apart."

The "weaker" have failed to "speak up . . . against the injustices" against the "Beloved Terra." These weaker people "only watch and participate in the reawakening of the planet with the strictness of the closed mindedness and the fear of breaking the habits and patterns that are controlled by the stronger." In other words, "weaker" people may realize that something is wrong but they don't dare to do something about it because their habits are controlled by other "stronger people." According to Ashtar, the energy of the "collective consciousness" must be "studied and observed at a critical speed for the recovery of the planet," and this "requires the leadership of the wisest of souls and the strongest of wills, who actually have the capability of standing up for the rights and injustices that have been allowed to occur." (Perhaps Ashtar meant to say it would have been better if the wise and strong stand up "for the rights and *against* the injustices.")

Ashtar then switched his message from the earth environment to outer space:

There is another matter of urgency regarding energy that we wish to share with you this evening. There is another dimensional frequency disturbance from a parallel universe that is coming within the orb of the Earth's influence within the next 20 years. This is a phenomenon that does not occur but once in a period of several thousand years. These words, while many on Earth will not fully understand them, are sent with much deliberation to you in respect to your position and the knowledge that you have, regarding our appearances and activities surrounding the Earth. We are positioned in the fifth dimensional frequency to try and assist in absorbing much of the shock from this orb of influence that is affecting the Earth in the third dimensional existence.

If this sounds ominous, don't worry. Ashtar has a solution:

Allow me to assure you that, from an energy standpoint, we are constantly maneuvering our ships to send energy waves and frequencies to the critical vortexes [sic] on the

Beloved earth, to try and counteract the negativity that seems to collect and hold within certain areas of the planet. We do not have to tell you that the negativity measurements far outweigh the lighter, more [sic] higher energy forms. Nor do we not [sic] have to report the states of the minds of most inhabitants on the earth today, for we feel that you can weigh those facts and data yourself and make the determination as to whether or not they contribute to the heavier or lighter weights that collect around your planet. In other words, we send you a valid message.

I interpret this statement as meaning that Ashtar's activities, some of which might be reported as flights of UFOs, are related to his attempt to protect the earth from what might be called the ultimate in bad vibrations caused by some five-dimensional object which has a projection into the third dimension and which is approaching earth. (A five-dimensional object would have a projection onto the third dimension, just as a third-dimensional object has a projection onto the second dimension—a surface—onto a first-dimensional object—a line. To get a "projection," imagine illuminating an object with a light and looking at its shadow on a surface or on a line.) Presumably the period of the 20-year threat is now nearly half over, inasmuch as this message was delivered nine years ago, in February 1989.

I confess I do not understand the meaning of sending "energy waves and frequencies to the critical vortexes" (vortices) of the earth. Where are these vortices, and why are they critical? Ashtar does not explain. Nor did he explain the meaning of negativity measurements and the "heavier or lighter weights that collect" around the earth. Ashtar's insistence that his message was valid notwithstanding, it contains a lot of meaningless material.

At last Ashtar turned to the subject of greatest interest to me: me. In glowing terms he expressed the challenges I face. Some abstracts from Norma's transcript:

You have been singled out for your leadership . . . for your wisdom . . . for your caring and constant search for the truth. . . . There is a constant struggle within your psyche . . . a constant battle within your soul. Your soul understands the connection back to the Light . . . to our ships and Beingness. . . . Your mind does not. Your mind witnesses fifth dimensional data with a struggle to transcend the third dimensional world. . . . The connection is through the soul. There is no other way. You have been selected . . . for this opportunity to "try out" for this leadership role [because] we believe you have the strength of soul to make the connections both from within to us and from without to your connections in the world around you . . . to bridge the gap between the seen and unseen . . . and only after that gap is bridged will we be able to communicate on the seen level. . . . That is why we have communicated this evening.

I had no idea I had so much "soul." After a few more kind words he ended the conversation:

Consider this message closed at this time and not one of the repeating of the other words [in other words, not a repeat of the earlier messages I had received from Joan], for they were not of the utmost significance that we deem these words are, and we do try and use our time and energy of the transmitter [channeler] of our messages with a greater wisdom. The urgency and the call to the attention of the matters of the third dimensional world are not as significant as those of the fifth.

Thank you for your time and know that I am the honored one to formally make the acquaintance of a Being who has the position and essence that you are deemed to have.

Good evening Brother in the Light. We sincerely do hope that this message does reflect the Light in your heart that so much wishes to be reconnected to your origins.

I AM Ashtar, in the Radiance and the brilliance of the Highest. Adonai.

Adonai, indeed. Wouldn't Shalom be more appropriate?

## WILL THE REAL ASHTAR BEAM DOWN?

So there you have it. The divergence between the Joan and Norma messages could hardly be more clear.

So which am I? The impudent one who is warned not to get in the way of Ashtar's activities even though I can't stop him, or am I the Brother in the Light striving to improve my soul and understanding so I can bridge the gap between the seen and the unseen and thereby reconnect to my spaceship origins?

Will the real Ashtar please beam me up?

I presume that my UFO-related activities could be known to any superintelligence visiting the earth. Perhaps my efforts could run counter to the designs of an intelligence which seeks to conduct its business covertly. I suppose it is at least imaginable that certain events in my life could have been directed by outside forces. Still and all, I don't believe it. I reject both Ashtars.

## EPILOGUE

This all happened a long time ago now. I did not write about it soon after it happened because, frankly, I was embarrassed. Perhaps I shouldn't have been. But I was. Furthermore, I figured that if there was anything to it, I would have to wait to find out whether the prediction of ruination would be fulfilled.

In the meantime, Norma published her channelings in a book, *We, the Arcturians*. Much of the material in this book is similar to material channeled by other persons.

I didn't see Joan often after her channeling sessions, maybe once or twice a year. I last saw her about five years ago. As of that time she had received no more messages from Ashtar and from any other self-identified space commander.

As for me, I have kept on doing what I have been doing. I have not received "whatever [I] want." On the other hand, I haven't been ruined either. Hence, it appears that the channeled messages haven't affected my life. Perhaps that means I have neither cooperated with nor obstructed Ashtar's mission. Or perhaps that means Ashtar is just a concoction of the New Age imagination.

And yet. . . .

That music came from somewhere.

*Editor's note:* Ashtar entered the mystical end of the flying-saucer movement on July 18, 1952, through the channeling of George Van Tassel, who with George Adamski would be the most influential of the early contactees. The name apparently comes from "ashar." Ashars figure in an 1882 book, *Oahspe*, based on automatic writing John Ballou Newbrough, a New York occultist, allegedly received from angels. According to *Oahspe*, a popular book among 1950s saucerians, ashars are guardian angels who travel in etheric spirit ships.

Ashtar is even the subject of a biography of sorts, *Ashtar: A Tribute*, prepared by a contactee known as Tuella (Thelma B. Turrell). Tuella writes, "Under the sponsorship of Lord Michael and the Great Central Sun government of this galaxy, Commander Ashtar is second only to the Beloved Commander Jesus-Sananda in responsibility for the airborne division of the Brotherhood of Light." At the same time, Ashtar's associate Korton has complained to Tuella, "As ridiculous as it may sound . . . some would say Ashtar didn't exist."

## 1911 UFO—continued from page 13

1911 and 1912 were largely ignorant of such things. But Idella was well educated, in any case.

Night after night, she would fill pages detailing her experiences, but my mother, feeling perhaps a little ashamed, burned them each morning.

Today I would like to have them to read. I know they would have contained the truth, according to my sister's light. ♦

### DELAYED DELIVERY

The Fall issue of *International UFO Reporter* was mailed several weeks late due to a delay at the U.S. Postal Service bulk mail facility in Chicago. We sincerely regret any inconvenience this may have caused our Associates.

We are in contact with postal service officials to insure that this problem doesn't occur again. Thanks for your understanding.

Mark Rodeghier  
President, CUFOs

---

## UFOs IN TASMANIA

The Tasmanian UFO Investigation Centre (TUFOIC), founded in 1965, continues its excellent work in UFO case investigation and analysis. Visit their Web site at [www.spacenet.net.au/~tufoic/](http://www.spacenet.net.au/~tufoic/) for recent reports and news from that part of Australia. Here is one recent report:

*June 24, 1997, Lachlan, Tasmania.* Mrs B. was home alone at 7:30 p.m. She was in the kitchen and noticed a bright light source on the kitchen blinds. Looking out, she was puzzled by a large circle of light seemingly at ground

level 200–300 meters to the east of the house. The circle was in a paddock at a higher elevation above the house. Mrs B. could see the fence posts in front of the light, which placed it in front of the trees at the other end of the paddock. She went outside for a better view but could not see any marks on the circle or hear any sound. The bright white light did not seem to reflect onto any of the nearby trees. She looked out soon after, but the light had disappeared. A search of the area failed to locate any traces or explanation. ♦

---

## LETTERS

### EVIDENCE IN ABDUCTION CASES

*To the editor:*

In his fascinating article in the Summer 1997 issue of *IUR*, Budd Hopkins reports on his interaction with Carl Sagan and his disappointment with Sagan's refusal to join him in investigating an abduction case.

As I see it, the central issue here is the two men's different definitions of what sort of evidence would be acceptable. Hopkins takes eyewitness testimony with apparently little question of its validity. Sagan would demand harder evidence and question whether eyewitness testimony, as Hopkins quotes Sagan, grows out of "some internal mental states they do not understand."

I suspect that Hopkins was so confident in his position that he would expect Sagan to agree with him during their proposed joint investigation, whereas Sagan would most likely seek to expand the investigation into "psychological" aspects and to announce a conclusion strikingly different from Hopkins's—leaving Hopkins more disappointed than ever.

ROBERT WANDERER  
*San Francisco, California*

*The larger point, however, is that according to Hopkins, Sagan declared an interest (ostensibly in true scientific spirit) in investigating an abduction case; but when one was presented to him, he declined—calling into question, inevitably, the sincerity of the original offer. Sagan did nothing to put at risk his continued membership in the group Allen Hynek used to call, tongue deeply in cheek, the Society for the Explanation of the Uninvestigated.—The Editor.*

### THE TRUTH ABOUT POLYGRAPHS

*To the editor:*

I read Geoff Price's article (*IUR*, Fall 1997, pp. 14–16, 31–32) with a great deal of interest. I think we are beginning a discussion in the form that Dr. Swords suggested in his article, also in that issue. A rational discussion of the facts, rather than a list of what is wrong with others in the UFO field.

Price makes a good point when he suggested that I didn't raise the issue of the polygraph methodology concerning the tests conducted by John McCarthy at the beginning of the Travis Walton case. He suggests that McCarthy's methods were 30 years out of date and induce their own bias in terms of the questions asked and the stress manufactured. But it seems that McCarthy was basing part of his opinion on what he believed were Travis Walton's attempts to "beat" the test. To McCarthy this suggested "gross deception." The argument that the methodology should be rejected because of its antiquity is to miss the real point which was Walton's apparent, to McCarthy, attempts to beat the test.

Price does not address the fact that George Pfeiffer, who conducted the second set of tests and labeled Walton as truthful, had the conclusion challenged by his boss, Tom Ezell. Once Ezell reviewed the test results, he thought the charts showed deception. Jerry Black, a UFO investigator in Ohio and interested in the Walton case, talked to both Pfeiffer and Ezell. Black told me that Pfeiffer, the man who conducted the tests felt that Walton had passed. Ezell, who might have wanted to keep his company out of the UFO arena (that is, had a personal reason for his conclusions), didn't agree.

It then comes down to the 1993 tests conducted by Cy Gilson. Jerry Black put great stock in those tests. Price apparently does as well. These tests suggested that Walton was telling the truth. I asked Jerry Black if he was satisfied with the results and he said that he was. These tests changed Black's mind. He went from a skeptic to a believer for what he considers good reason.

Price also suggests that there is no scientific evidence for the allegation that the validity of this last test would be suspect if the subject was telling a tale that had become part of his life for more than twenty years. Price wrote about polygraph expert Charles Honts, who said, "In fact the available research fails to show such effects, but no study has looked at time intervals in terms of years." Please note that Honts, and Price, are admitting that there is no study upon which they can base their conclusion.

The empirical evidence, however, suggested by those who operate the polygraphs for various police agencies, has suggested just that, as I have learned in discussions with the

San Bernardino County Sheriff's department in California. That no scientific studies have been conducted does not mean that there isn't a degradation of the effectiveness of those tests in such circumstances. Until the proper tests have been run, we do have the empirical evidence, and no scientific reason to reject it.

It seems to me that we still have a wash on the polygraph evidence in the Walton case. Price makes valid points when he suggests that the polygraph results should be carefully reviewed, that McCarthy's testing methods were out of date, and the reliability of the polygraph has improved. He fails when he suggests that we reject the empirical evidence that long term telling of a specific story might insulate the tale and give a false positive result.

In regard to the Walters "Gulf Breeze" case, it seems that the evidence is in. Price rejects the Tommy Smith voice stress analysis because it was uncontrolled. He also rejects it because, according to Charles Honts, "There is no published evidence to support the validity of the VSA." Okay, fair enough.

However, there is a problem when Price suggests that "... the elimination of the VSA claims leaves only the passed polygraph test administered by Harvey McLaughlin in February 1988 as far as PDD [psychological detection of deception] evidence goes. Reports seem to indicate that this test was competently administered, though details are scarce."

Rex and Carol Salisbury sent all the relevant information about these tests to the Florida Polygraph Association. Billy J. Rakes, then the president, wrote back, telling them that an "overall fair and impartial analysis could not be made without the complete data from the exams."

Rakes also noted that McLaughlin, quoted by Price, had never been a member of the Florida Polygraph Association, nor any professional polygraph association which adheres to standards of practice, principles and ethical conduct of polygraph examinations.

But more importantly, Rakes echoed a cautionary note that had been raised by Hugh Jones, a Florida UFO investigator, after Walters failed to appear for the first test scheduled by a disinterested third party. Rakes said that self-sponsored tests taken by Walters are not advisable. (The first test was arranged by others, and the one that Walters eventually took was arranged by Walters.) Jones had said, "Can one imagine the predicament of the polygraphist in having to tell the client, 'Well, sir, your tests show that you are lying. That will be \$200, please.'"

The conclusion then, of the examiners questioned by the Salisberrys, and of the president of the state board in Florida, was that self-sponsored examinations, such as that given to Walters by McLaughlin, mean very little. Couple that to the problems with the report written by McLaughlin in which he writes, "With the information that is available to this examiner at this time, it is felt that Mr. Walters truly [sic] believes that the photographs and personal sitings [sic] he has described are true and factual to the best of his

ability." Rakes, in his letter to the Salisberrys wrote, "The paragraph under 'opinion' indicated the examiner based his opinion on his 'feelings' by stating 'it is felt' the examinee answered truthfully. Experts in the field base their conclusions and opinions on careful analysis of the examinee's physiological reactions noted on the polygraphs during the examination," so a good case can be made that none of the tests are valid.

In other words, the tests were not valid. Walters at best was ill-informed about the validity of the tests. At worst, he was misrepresenting the situation in an attempt to elevate his flagging reputation by claiming that he had passed four different polygraph examinations.

But that isn't the end of the lie detector tests. In 1988 Robert Oeschler, a self-promoted UFO expert, submitted two taped interviews to Dektor Counterintelligence & Security, Inc. in Glen Burnie, Maryland for voice stress analysis. These two tapes are apparently the rest of the basis for Walters' claim of four lie detector tests. The two administered by McLaughlin and the two voice stress analyses which are not, of course, the same as a polygraph. And, if we accept the assessment by Price, these tests are virtually useless as evidence.

The report, which was signed by Michael P. Kradz said, "The way the interviews were done and the type of information discussed does not give the examiner the verbal material necessary for him to be able to say if these individuals are being completely truthful with the interviewer."

So, there aren't actually four lie detector tests that Walters passed as he had claimed. There are two self-sponsored tests, and the two voice stress tests that were inconclusive. When Walters wrote to the *MUFON UFO Journal*, "I have taken and passed four lie detector tests administered by three different examiners, all of whom signed their reports," he wasn't being strictly accurate. It could be argued that a man whose reputation has been challenged has the right to a little self promotion, but some of what he said in that same published letter was intentionally misleading.

For example, Walters wrote about the voice stress tests by Dektor, "The rest of the interview, for what its worth from the standpoint of being able to say he is being truthful about what he saw and what he did, *does not show any reactions to cause this examiner to doubt his answers* [emphasis added by Walters]."

But like so much else in this case, that is not the final word. Walters ended the statement with a period after the word answers. It should have been a comma, because it continued, "but the interview is not covering any specifics, therefore is a more general discussion and it appears Ed is enjoying the discussion mainly about photography."

So, Walters, in his attempt to validate his sightings and his photographs, took the portions of the letter that he wanted, quoted only the parts that supported him, and left out the rest. For someone attempting to rebuild his reputa-

tion, this sort of deceit doesn't speak well of him.

Where are we then? Price makes some very good arguments in favor of Walton, especially in his descriptions of the current state of polygraph science. There are other factors in this case which suggest to me that it is a hoax. A case should not rise or fall on polygraph results. And Price is right when he suggests that we each should assign weight to each of the facts according to our own opinions and knowledge. What might be of little importance to him, might be of greater importance to someone else.

Price fares less well on Walters and Gulf Breeze. There seems to be no lie detector evidence to support Walters when all the facts are assessed. Given the preponderance of other, persuasive evidence, the Ed Walters aspect of Gulf Breeze seems to be a hoax.

KEVIN D. RANDLE  
*Cedar Rapids, Iowa*

## ROSWELL, THE AIR FORCE, AND CUFOS

*To the editor:*

I would like to comment on the articles concerning the Roswell incident in the Fall 1997 *IUR*.

Concerning Mark Rodeghier and Mark Chesney's article ("Who's the Dummy Now? The Latest Air Force Report," pp. 7-10): I read with much interest Capt. James McAndrew's report. I think Roswell researchers, who expressed so much criticism of the first Air Force report because it didn't mention the bodies, should be grateful that McAndrew has now addressed the subject. McAndrew takes seriously the witnesses' accounts. That doesn't mean that he believes them, only that he thinks they didn't just concoct their story with details coming out of the blue. McAndrew thinks that the details of their stories have their origin in airplane crashes that happened in the 1950s.

We should recognize that in each case, McAndrew made the effort to find events that include details close to those reported by the witnesses. But we can also propose another explanation for the coincidences: The witnesses may have come up with stories similar to documented aeronautical crashes because the vocabulary they used came out of aeronautics.

Consider the following example taken from my research on Kenneth Arnold. Arnold (who launched the controversy in 1947, contrary to the current popular belief that everything started in Roswell). Arnold speaks of nine objects traveling at twice the speed of sound and behaving like a saucer skipped across water. In Bill Bequette's AP dispatch the saucerlike movement became a saucerlike shape. Strangely, we find a story uncannily like Arnold's account in the May 1947 issue of *Mechanix Illustrated*. Writing of the Navy's Flying Flapjack, reporter Gilbert Paust described the airplane as saucer-shaped. The article closes with this sentence: "So don't be amazed when one of these days you hear a whistling sound from the sky and see a blurred, circular object sailing across the heavens at a

speed never before attained by man! It will be the Navy's Flapjack, the XF5U, breaking through another frontier in aviation's history."

A first reaction could be to say that Arnold knew about this article and made up his news-breaking story from it. But I don't think that is the case. The same details appear not only in the *Mechanix Illustrated* article on the Flapjack but also in other papers on aeronautics. Conclusion: Arnold just used a vocabulary that was, so to speak, "in the air" (there are, of course, also many other arguments that concur to show that Arnold was sincerely reporting something he considered anomalous).

Is this the solution to the striking similarities found by McAndrew? Perhaps in part. But in part only. Because when we consider Glenn Dennis's story, the similarities cannot be accounted for by a contextual coincidence.

Now, turning to Michael D. Swords's "Roswell: Clashing Visions of the Possible," pp. 11-13, 33-35): I doubt there was a cover-up of Roswell because I don't think the Roswell debris was strange. I agree with Robert Todd, Karl Pflock, Col. Richard Weaver, Capt. McAndrew, Prof. Charles Moore, other UFO researchers, and—more recently—Kent Jeffrey that the Mogul explanation is reasonable. And I think that the nonappearance of any evidence of a cover-up in all the documents released recently (like the SAB meeting of 1948 released to Bill LaParl) makes a strong case against the existence of any such cover-up.

I find Swords's examples of other cover-ups interesting, and I think it would be a very good exercise—especially for people who don't buy the cover-up solution—to try at least to build a case for a Roswell cover-up even if it's just a game. It's always a good thing to try to see matters from an opponent's perspective.

But if the Roswell skeptics agree to play the game, pro-Roswell researchers should agree to recognize some points made by their opponents.

1. The fact that Jesse Marcel may have made a mistake is not so shameful. The history of science, for example, is full of serious errors committed by brilliant people. And the fact that (as skeptics contend) Marcel didn't recognize debris from a Mogul balloon doesn't render him an idiot.

2. The debate is not between the Air Force and the UFO community. It is between researchers who accept the Mogul explanation and researchers who reject it. I don't think we advance ufology by always emphasizing the Air Force's support of the Mogul explanation. After all, the Air Force investigators took a chance when they elected to work on a difficult case like Roswell. I am sure there are better ways to attain promotion in a conservative agency like the U.S. Air Force.

This is even more true for the second report. This time the General Accounting Office didn't ask anything of the Air Force. But McAndrew took over the risky task of examining the stories concerning the bodies. Even if we disagree with him, we should give him credit for doing a lot of work in search of a "reasonable explanation" again.

Of course, as Swords writes, both camps have their extremists, but we also find people who agree to discuss and who agree to disagree. There should be space in *IUR* for an intelligent and respectful debate between them. From this point of view, Kent Jeffrey's article published recently in the June 1997 *MUFON UFO Journal* is a good starting point.

I close this long letter recalling another UFO debate, one that happened in 1988. At that time, the UFO community was divided on the Gulf Breeze, Florida, case. MUFON promoted the pro-Gulf Breeze side, while CUFOS tended to publish skeptical views. The reverse is now happening; the *MUFON UFO Journal* publishes more skeptical papers than *IUR*. People who don't read both journals miss part of the story.

It's too bad, and it gives the impression that there is a great divide between two opposing factions. We tend often to get frozen in the image we give of ourselves. (If people think we are skeptics or believers, then we play skeptic or believer.)

There are, in fact, more than two sides. Therefore, reducing people to the categories of believers or skeptics doesn't do justice to their views and work. CUFOS should be careful not to project an image of Roswell advocacy. If by any chance in the near future it balances its view on some point, it will look as if it is giving in to its critics.

I remember when I was at CUFOS in 1988 doing my research on Kenneth Arnold. I participated in the first discussions on the reopening of the Roswell investigation. All different kind of hypotheses were discussed then.

CUFOS has a scientific mission regarding UFOs. Remember the work of Hynek, of course, but also of brilliant investigators such as Allan Hendry, who was neither skeptic nor believer but who did splendid work.

In my opinion the best work is being done by persons whose views on UFOs cannot be conveniently tagged.

PIERRE LAGRANGE  
*Paris, France*

*Mark Rodeghier and Mark Chesney respond:*

Pierre Lagrange's comments are an odd mixture of conjecture and assertion, and he evinces a misunderstanding of the nature and consequences of real-world investigations. We'll begin with the last topic.

Lagrange tells us of his (fleeting and coincidental) participation in early discussions of Roswell at CUFOS, before considerable new critical evidence about the event was available, much of it through the efforts of CUFOS investigators. He then complains that the CUFOS position is unbalanced because we present fewer skeptical articles on the case. Yet the goal of CUFOS, our "scientific mission," to use Lagrange's words, is to state and act upon the truth and best evidence as we see it. To do less would be intellectually dishonest. And so with Roswell, where the evidence for the several Air Force explanations is wanting, we are obligated to stand by the evidence for the unusual nature of the debris

and the existence of a cover-up at the time of the event.

It seems that Lagrange would counsel CUFOS to discount the direction the evidence points, in our judgment, in favor of presenting a balanced position on the case, just so our views can't be "conveniently tagged." We find this to be a rather absurd bit of advice that seems to be predicated on some abstract principles of fairness and balance that do not apply to the way a scientific investigation is (or should) be done. Fortunately, U.S. equal-time laws have yet to be applied to UFO research.

A similar flaw lies behind Lagrange's complaint that people who don't read both the *MUFON UFO Journal* and *IUR* are given "the impression that there is a great divide between the two opposing factions." Well, guess what, there is a great divide between the two camps on Roswell (though not between MUFON and CUFOS, we hasten to add), and this is hardly something CUFOS has created or fostered. Furthermore, such divides exist in almost all areas of science where there are great controversies.

As a current example, consider the debate about whether an asteroid caused the demise of the dinosaurs. Feelings between paleontologists and geologists, on one side of the issue, and astronomers and physicists on the other side, are frosty and not always very civil. The two camps disagree rather vehemently, but that is the way that much of science is conducted. Lagrange appears either to not understand this or he wishes to hold ufologists to an unrealistic ideal. Of course we advocate reasoned debate and civil discourse, and we engage in the same on a regular basis with those of opposing views. But the divide exists, whether we like it or not.

Lagrange's comments on our article about the latest Air Force report are somewhat difficult to interpret, especially his enigmatic statement about the Glenn Dennis testimony. He praises McAndrew for taking the witness accounts of bodies and crashes seriously and not rejecting them out of hand, and he asks us to be "grateful" that McAndrew addressed this aspect of Roswell.

Okay, fair enough, we'll admit being grateful, but not for the reason Lagrange suggests. Instead, we are grateful because the woeful nature of the investigation and proffered explanation demonstrates the weakness of the Air Force position on Roswell. We would truly be appreciative if McAndrew had actually done an in-depth investigation, with extensive interviews of relevant witnesses, then been fair-minded in his approach to the evidence.

Finally, we ask this rhetorical question, in response to another of Lagrange's assertions: Who says that Richard Weaver and James McAndrew, the primary Air Force investigators, "elected to work on a difficult case like Roswell?" This statement demonstrates a clear lack of understanding of how the military functions, which may help us to understand Lagrange's view of the military's behavior in 1947. Rather, we should ask, did Weaver and McAndrew leap, or were they pushed? ♦

# ASSOCIATE APPLICATION FORM

Name \_\_\_\_\_

☐ New associate

☐ Renewal

Street Address \_\_\_\_\_

City \_\_\_\_\_

State \_\_\_\_\_

Zip \_\_\_\_\_

## =====

### ASSOCIATE LEVEL

### ASSOCIATE BENEFITS

(Please make payment in U.S. funds only)

|                 |           |                                                                                 |
|-----------------|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sustaining      | \$25.00   | <i>International UFO Reporter (IUR)</i>                                         |
| Contributing    | \$50.00   | <i>IUR</i> plus one Center publication **                                       |
| Donor           | \$100.00  | <i>IUR</i> plus two Center publications** or one <i>Alien Abductions</i> video† |
| Sponsor         | \$250.00  | <i>IUR</i> , two publications & one Center case**                               |
| Research patron | \$500.00  | <i>IUR</i> , two publications & two Center cases**                              |
| Benefactor      | \$1000.00 | <i>IUR</i> for life, two cases/yr., and new CUFOS publications free**           |

**Please Note: This application form is for U.S. residents only.**

=====

Register me as an Associate of CUFOS at the following level: \_\_\_\_\_

Amount: \$ \_\_\_\_\_

Also enclosed is my personal contribution of: \$ \_\_\_\_\_

**TOTAL ENCLOSED:** \$ \_\_\_\_\_

1/98

\*\* Associates at the Contributing level or higher are entitled to one or more of the following publications:

- ☐ Check here if you wish no publications
- ☐ **NEW!** *Project 1947: A Preliminary Report* (Jan Aldrich, 1997)
- ☐ **NEW!** *The Oz Files* (Bill Chalker, 1996)
- ☐ **NEW!** *On Pilots and UFOs* (Willy Smith, 1997)
- ☐ *Journal of UFO Studies*, New Series, Volume 6 (1995/96)
- ☐ *New CUFOS Document Packet #1* (Preliminary Study of Unidentified Targets on Air Traffic Control Radars (1953); letter from Dr. James E. McDonald to Robert Low criticizing the Condon Committee (1968); Preliminary draft of recommendations on the UFO Project, by J. Allen Hynek (1953); USAF UFO briefing, mid-1955))
- ☐ *New CUFOS Document Packet #2* (Letter from J. Allen Hynek to Hector Quintanilla (1969); transcript of meetings of Unidentified Aerial Phenomena Advisory Panel (1959); Blue Book briefing papers with specific Congressmen (1960); Special Report on Conferences with Astronomers on UAOs, by Hynek (1952); USAF public relations response to UFO inquiries (1953))

The *International UFO Reporter* is published 4 times a year and mailed to all current Associates of CUFOS.

**Thank you for your support of the Center for UFO Studies!**

Mail this form and your contribution (checks payable to CUFOS) to:

**The J. Allen Hynek Center for UFO Studies, 2457 W. Peterson Ave., Chicago, IL 60659; (773) 271-3611**